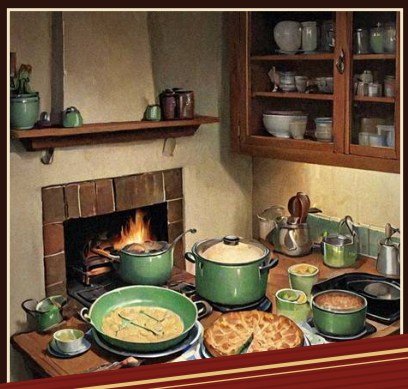
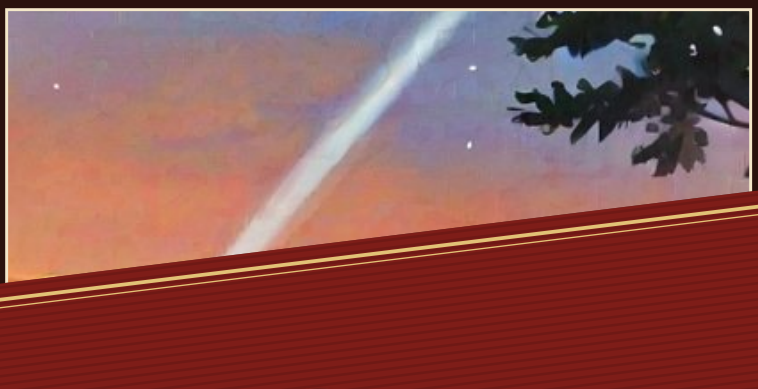


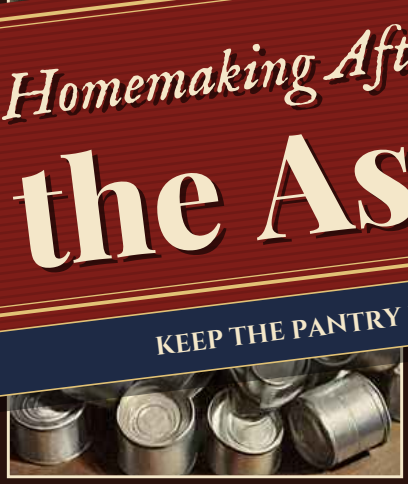
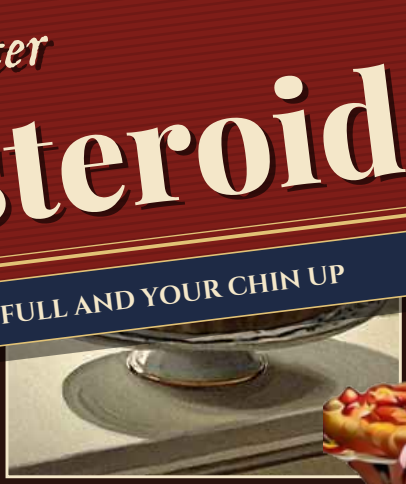






Homemaking After the Asteroid

KEEP THE PANTRY FULL AND YOUR CHIN UP







HOMEMAKING AFTER THE ASTEROID



EX LIBRIS

This book belongs to

_____
__

and their household, _____

Homemaking After the ASTEROID

60 Cheerful Skills for Keeping a Lovely Home When the Sky Has Fallen In

AN ILLUSTRATED HANDBOOK OF CHEERFUL HOUSEKEEPING FOR THE CRATER AGE

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION · 2026

Homemaking After the Asteroid: 60 Cheerful Skills for Keeping a Lovely Home When the Sky Has Fallen In. Fun Books Home Edition, 2026.

Written and illustrated as an original work. The text and pictures in this book were created from scratch for this edition and are not copied from any other publication.

Please read before using this book. This is a work of good-natured humor. Every family, warden, scientist, grocer and meteorite in it is made up. Real meteorites are not warm, do not glow and should never be cooked on, and real emergencies call for the advice of your local authorities, not this book. Please do not climb into craters or lick anything from outer space. Do try the mock apple pie.

Printing tips. This book is laid out on US Letter (8.5 x 11 in) pages. Print double-sided, “flip on long edge”, at 100% scale. For a book that lies flat on the kitchen table, ask a copy shop for spiral or comb binding with a clear front and a heavy back cover.

Made with care for everyone who ever kept breakfast hot while the world was ending.

For every homemaker who swept the step
the morning after the sky fell in.

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INTRODUCTION

How to use this book

There was a time, not so long ago, when the worst thing that could happen to an American kitchen was a fallen souffle. Then, one Tuesday morning, an asteroid landed in the rose bed. The sky turned orange, the power went out, a fine gray dust settled over everything and a glowing green rock the size of a pumpkin took up residence on the back step.

Most homemakers are not ready. Nobody teaches housekeeping for the crater age at school. The old cookbooks say nothing about baking on a meteorite, rationing cookies under Father's nose or keeping a hairdo through a dust storm. This book is here to help.

What you'll find inside. Sixty skills in nine chapters, each on a single page laid out the same way: a picture for every step, a short explanation of why it matters, a materials panel with what you'll need, and a notes panel with tips and the most important warnings. Colored tabs on the edge of every page tell you which chapter you're in, so you can find the right page quickly, even during a pebble shower.

How to use it. Don't wait for the sky to fall. Read the first chapter tonight. Stock the pantry. Find the hand-crank can opener (third drawer down, under the birthday candles). Put two candles and a box of matches where you can find them in the dark. Each skill you practice now is one less surprise the morning after.

Start with the basics. If the asteroid has already landed, begin with Chapter 1 (the morning after), the pantry in Chapter 2, the mock apple pie in Chapter 3 and the dusting in Chapter 4. Those four alone will put your household well ahead of the Hendersons, who are still trying to get the ash out of their piano.

The appendix at the back gathers the charts and checklists you'll reach for most: a field guide to who and what you will meet, a pantry chart with trading values, household remedies for crater-age mishaps, handy conversions, checklists, a household card, a glossary, and a log for the skills your household has mastered.

A word on cheerfulness. The end of the world is a great deal less frightening with a hot breakfast on the table. Watch for the boxes marked **Important**, and remember that the best shelter in any disaster is a tidy kitchen, a full pantry and a homemaker who refuses to be anything but cheerful.

CHAPTERS AT A GLANCE

CHAPTER	WHAT IT COVERS	SKILLS
1. The Morning After	What to do when the sky falls in on a Tuesday	6
2. The Fallout Pantry	Stocking, sorting and rationing the shelves that saved the family	7
3. Recipes for the Crater Age	Cheerful cooking from the fallout pantry	7
4. Keeping House in the Dust	Cleaning, washing and ironing when the whole world needs a wipe	7
5. The Backyard Crater	Making the most of a very large hole	6
6. The Family Underground	Making the basement shelter cozy, cheerful and full of board games	6
7. Out and About in the New World	Shopping, visiting and keeping up standards around town	7
8. When the Sky Acts Up	Pebble showers, tremors, green sunsets and other new kinds of weather	7
9. Brighter Days Ahead	Parties, prizes and the cheerful homemaker every crater needs	7

CHAPTER ONE

1

THE MORNING AFTER

What to do when the sky falls in on a Tuesday







It landed on a Tuesday, which is wash day, which was very inconsiderate. There was a flash, a rumble and a thump, and when Mother looked out of the kitchen window the rose bed had become a crater the size of a swimming pool. The sky turned the color of orange sherbet. Father said it would blow over. A sensible homemaker does not wait for things to blow over. She puts on her apron, sweeps the step and gets breakfast on the table. This chapter shows her how.

IN THIS CHAPTER

01 Discovering a Crater Where the Rose Bed Was
02 Sweeping Space Dust off the Front Step
03 Tuning In to the Emergency Broadcast
04 Checking on the Neighbors (With a Casserole)
05 Calming the Canary (and Father)
06 Serving Breakfast When the Power Is Out

HOW TO

DISCOVERING A CRATER WHERE THE ROSE BED WAS

SKILL 01 · THE MORNING AFTER · 10 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A cup of coffee



- Your garden gloves



- A pair of binoculars



- A pencil and notepad



- Your sunniest attitude



Every homemaker has a moment when she looks out of the kitchen window and something is different. Usually it is a new birdbath at the Hendersons'. This time it is a hole forty feet across where the prize roses used to be. Stay calm. A crater is just a garden that has not been planted yet.

1



Look Out of the Window

Pour your coffee first. Then look. It will still be there.

2



Step Outside Calmly

Walk, do not run. Wear sensible shoes. The lawn is a little lumpy now.

3

Take a Good Look

Binoculars help. Note the size, the smoke and whether anything in the bottom is glowing.



4



Mourn the Roses Briefly

Thirty seconds of silence for the Peace roses. Then move on.

5



Measure It for Later

Pace it out. Forty paces across makes a very nice pond, or a sunken garden.

6



Write It on the List

Add 'crater' to the week's chores, between 'wash day' and 'defrost the icebox'.

NOTES

A crater looks much smaller once there is a nice fence around it. See Chapter 5.

IMPORTANT

Do not climb down into the crater in your good shoes. The sides are crumbly, and Father will have to fetch the ladder.

HOW TO

SWEEPING SPACE DUST OFF THE FRONT STEP

SKILL 02 · THE MORNING AFTER · 15 MINUTES · EASY

After the asteroid, a fine gray dust settled over the whole town like powdered sugar on a doughnut. It is on the porch, on the car, on the milk bottles and on the cat. The neighbors will judge you by your front step. Sweep it first.

1



Tie On a Head Scarf

Dust loves a fresh set. A cheerful scarf keeps your hair nice.

2



Start at the Door

Always sweep away from the house, never toward it.

3



Sweep Down the Steps

One step at a time, top to bottom, like icing a cake.

MATERIALS


A straw broom


A dustpan


A head scarf


A watering can


An apron with deep pockets

4



Sprinkle to Settle

A light sprinkle from the watering can stops it blowing back in your face.

5



Pan It Up

Do not just push it into the flower bed. The petunias have suffered enough.

NOTES

A damp tea towel over the doormat catches most of what comes in on Father's shoes.

IMPORTANT

Do not sweep dust into Mrs. Henderson's yard, even if she has done it to you. Two wrongs make a very dusty street.



6 ### *Wave to the Neighbors*

They are sweeping too. Wave with the broom. It shows solidarity.

HOW TO

TUNING IN TO THE EMERGENCY BROADCAST

SKILL 03 · THE MORNING AFTER · 10 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A tabletop tube radio



- Fresh batteries



- A pencil and notepad



- A pot of coffee



- Patience



When the sky falls in, the radio comes into its own. The television shows only snow and the telephone only hums, but a good tube radio will bring you the man from Civil Defense, the weather and, if you are lucky, a little Perry Como.

1



Warm Up the Tubes

Switch it on and wait. Tube radios are like Father in the morning.

2



Turn the Dial Slowly

The emergency station is near the end. Go slowly or you will miss it.

3

Sit Down and Listen

Everyone sits. Nobody crunches cereal during the announcements.



4



Write Down What They Say

Times, places, where to collect water. The radio will not repeat itself for you.

5



Ignore the Dramatic Parts

Announcers love the word 'cataclysmic'. You need the word 'Thursday'.

6



Find Some Music After

Once the news is done, find a dance band. Morale is a household duty.

NOTES

Keep a spare set of batteries taped to the back of the radio. Nobody can find anything the morning after an asteroid.

IMPORTANT

Do not let Grandfather adjust the aerial with a fork. We have been over this.

HOW TO

CHECKING ON THE NEIGHBORS (WITH A CASSEROLE)

SKILL 04 · THE MORNING AFTER · 1 HOUR · EASY

A good neighbor appears at the door within the hour, and she never arrives empty-handed. Whatever has happened on Elm Street, a tuna casserole says 'We are all in this together' better than any speech from the mayor.

1



Bake Something Warm

Tuna and noodles, potato chips on top. It travels well and forgives everything.

2



Set It on a Tea Towel

Fold the towel up over the top before you go. It keeps it warm and keeps the dust off.

3



Walk Next Door

Carry it in a basket with the towel tucked over the top. Hold it level. A casserole is a promise.

MATERIALS


A tuna casserole


Two pot holders


A tea towel


Your address book


Comfortable shoes

4



Knock Gently

They have had a shock too. Two soft knocks, then a cheery 'Yoo-hoo!'

5



Ask What They Need

Candles? Water? A hand with the windows? Write it down.

NOTES

Tape your name to the bottom of the dish. In the confusion after a disaster, casserole dishes go astray.

IMPORTANT

Mrs. Henderson cannot eat tuna. Take her the cheese one.



6 ### *Leave the Dish*

Tell them to keep the dish until Sunday. That gives them a reason to visit.

HOW TO

CALMING THE CANARY (AND FATHER)

SKILL 05 · THE MORNING AFTER · 20 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A canary in a cage



- A cage cover



- A red apple



- A pot of tea



- Father's slippers



Petey the canary has not stopped flapping since Tuesday. Father has not stopped pacing. Both are perfectly natural reactions to an asteroid, and both respond well to the same treatment: a quiet room, a cover over the cage and a little something to nibble.

1



Cover the Cage

A dark cage is a calm cage. Use the flowered cover.

2



Speak Softly

Canaries and husbands both settle to a low, kind voice.

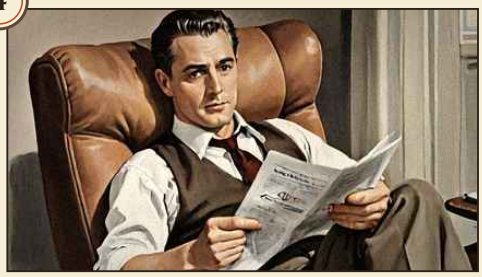
3

Offer a Treat

A slice of apple for Petey. A slice of pie for Father.



4



Sit Father in His Chair

Put his slippers by his feet and the newspaper in his hands, even if it is Monday's.

5



Pour the Tea

Strong, two sugars. For Father, not Petey.

6



Draw the Curtains

If neither of them can see the orange sky, neither of them will mention it.

NOTES

A ticking clock beside the cage soothes a canary. A ticking clock beside Father reminds him he is late for work.

IMPORTANT

Never let the canary out to 'see the crater'. You will spend the afternoon on a ladder.

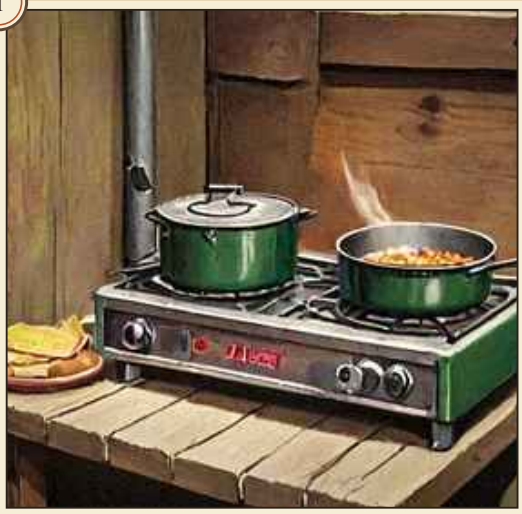
HOW TO

SERVING BREAKFAST WHEN THE POWER IS OUT

SKILL 06 · THE MORNING AFTER · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The electric range is out, the toaster is full of dust and the percolator is sulking. The family still needs breakfast, and a homemaker still serves it hot. Bring out the camp stove, light a candle and carry on.

1



Set Up the Camp Stove

On the back step, never in the kitchen. It is a stove, not a houseguest.

2



Heat the Skillet

Cast iron holds its heat. Give it a minute and a dab of butter.

3



Crack the Eggs

Sunny side up. It is the least anyone can do for the sunshine.

MATERIALS


A camp stove


A cast-iron skillet


A dozen eggs


A tin coffee pot


Two candles in holders

4



Boil the Coffee

Cowboy coffee in a tin pot. Father will say it tastes like the war.

5



Light the Table

Two candles make a dark kitchen look like a nice restaurant.

NOTES

Toast on a fork over the camp stove is a treat the children will ask for long after the power comes back.

IMPORTANT

Keep the camp stove well away from the curtains. You have only just got the dust out of them.



6 ### *Call Everyone Down*

Ring the little bell. Breakfast is breakfast, asteroid or no asteroid.

CHAPTER TWO

2

THE FALLOUT PANTRY

Stocking, sorting and rationing the shelves that saved the family







Mother always said a full pantry was a happy home, and after the asteroid she was proved right in front of the whole street. While the grocery was closed for dusting, our basement shelves held forty-two cans of soup, a ham in a tin, enough powdered milk to fill a bathtub and a jar of maraschino cherries for emergencies. This chapter is about the pantry: filling it, sorting it, guarding it from Father and making it last.

IN THIS CHAPTER

07 Stocking the Fallout Pantry
08 Labeling Cans After the Labels Fall Off
09 Making Powdered Milk Taste Like Milk
10 Opening a Can Without the Electric Opener
11 Rationing the Cookies So Father Doesn't Notice
12 Storing Water in Every Jar in the House
13 Keeping the Pantry Safe From Midnight Snackers

HOW TO

STOCKING THE FALLOUT PANTRY

SKILL 07 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

A fallout pantry is just an ordinary pantry with ambition. You will want canned goods, dry goods, water and a few treats to keep spirits up. Arrange it the way the grocer does, with the oldest at the front.

1



Sort the Shelves

Out go the old paint cans and Father's fishing magazines. Then put like with like.

2



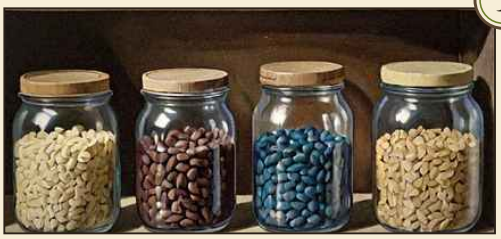
Line Up the Cans

Soups together, vegetables together, fruit on the top shelf where the children cannot reach.

3

Fill the Jars

Beans, rice and macaroni keep for ages in glass jars with good lids.



4



Stack the Flour

Up off the floor, on a board. Mice have heard about the asteroid too.

5



Add a Few Treats

Cherries, cocoa, a tin of shortbread. Morale is a food group.

6



Admire Your Work

Stand back. Fold your arms. Feel prepared.

NOTES

Write the date on each can with a grease pencil the day you bring it home. Your future self will thank you.

IMPORTANT

Do not stock anything you would not eat now. An asteroid does not make creamed chipped beef any more delicious.

MATERIALS

- Sturdy wooden shelves



- Canned goods



- A sack of flour



- Glass jars of beans



- A grocery list



HOW TO

LABELING CANS AFTER THE LABELS FALL OFF

SKILL 08 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The basement got damp after the impact and every paper label slid off every can. We now own sixty identical silver cylinders. Some are peaches. Some are dog food. A clever girl can tell them apart with a little detective work.

MATERIALS


A box of unlabeled cans


A grease pencil


A kitchen scale


A notebook


A magnifying glass

1



Gather the Mystery Cans

Put them all on the kitchen table. Do not let anyone open one 'just to see'.

2



Shake Each One

Peaches slosh. Beans thud. Soup sloshes and thuds.

3



Weigh Them

Heavy small cans are often meat. Light tall cans are often trouble.

4



Check the Bottom

Factories stamp little codes on the ends. A magnifying glass helps.

5



Mark Your Guess

Write 'P?' for peaches, 'S?' for soup, and 'Mystery' for the rest.



6 *Open One for Supper*

Every night, open one 'Mystery'. It keeps dinner exciting.

NOTES

Mystery Night is now the most popular night of the week in our house. Last Tuesday it was pineapple rings and corned beef. Together. It was not bad.

IMPORTANT

If it is dog food, it is dog food. Do not 'make it work' with a little parsley.

HOW TO

MAKING POWDERED MILK TASTE LIKE MILK

SKILL 09 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · 10 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The milkman has not been round since the impact. He is fine; the dairy is just under four feet of dust. Powdered milk is the answer, and the secret to making the children drink it is entirely in the presentation.

MATERIALS

- A box of powdered milk



- A glass pitcher



- A long spoon



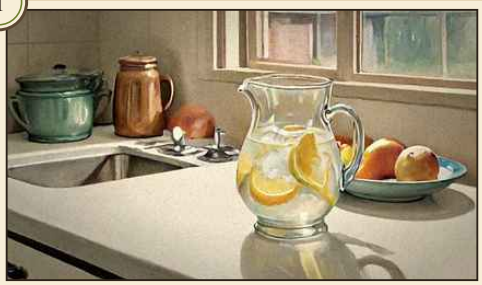
- A pinch of sugar



- A drop of vanilla



1



Use Cold Water

Warm water makes it taste like library paste. Use the coldest water you have.

2



Stir in the Powder

Add it slowly and stir as if you meant it. Lumps are the enemy.

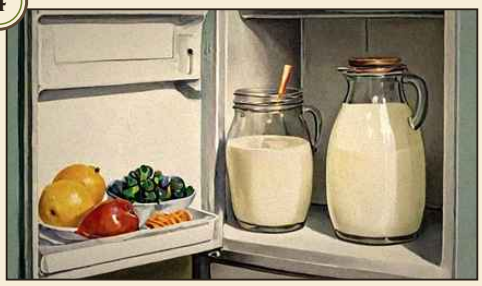
3

Add the Secret

A pinch of sugar and a drop of vanilla. Do not tell.



4



Chill It Overnight

Cold milk is milk. Warm powdered milk is a punishment.

5



Pour It From a Real Bottle

Children believe glass bottles. Save one from before.

6



Serve With Cookies

Nobody has ever complained about milk with a cookie in it.

NOTES

Powdered milk makes a perfectly good white sauce, rice pudding or cocoa. In cooking, nobody can tell.

IMPORTANT

Do not let Grandfather mix it. He makes it the way he made it in the Navy, and the spoon stands up on its own.

HOW TO

OPENING A CAN WITHOUT THE ELECTRIC OPENER

SKILL 10 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Last Christmas Father bought Mother an electric can opener. Then the power went out. Grandfather, who has opened cans in three countries and one war, is happy to show the family how it was done before everything had a plug.

MATERIALS


A hand-crank can opener


A church key


A can of beans


A dish towel


A steady hand

1



Admire the Electric Opener

Give it a pat. It was a lovely gift. It is now a paperweight.

2



Find the Hand Opener

Third drawer down, under the birthday candles. Always.

3



Clamp It On

Fit the wheel over the rim and squeeze the handles tight.

4



Turn the Crank

Slow and steady, all the way round, like winding a clock.

5



Lift the Lid Carefully

The edge is sharp. Use the tip of a knife, not your thumb.



6 *Teach the Grandchildren*

Every child should know how. Hold their hands on the first one.

NOTES

A church key opens juice cans with two neat triangles. Keep one on a string by the pantry door.

IMPORTANT

Do not use the hatchet, Father. We all saw what happened to the tomato soup.

HOW TO

RATIONING THE COOKIES SO FATHER DOESN'T NOTICE

SKILL 11 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · ONGOING · HARD

The cookie jar is down to its last two dozen and nobody knows when the bakery will reopen. Father has a sweet tooth and a sixth sense for the cookie jar. Rationing must be firm, fair and, above all, invisible.

1



Count the Cookies

Know exactly what you have. Knowledge is power.

2



Hide Most of Them

Put twenty in a plain tin on the top shelf, behind the gravy boat.

3

Leave a Few in the Jar

Four cookies in the jar keeps everyone happy and nobody suspicious.



4



Refill at Night

Two a night, after the children are asleep. Like the tooth fairy.

5



Keep a Straight Face

When Father asks why the jar never empties, say 'Good management, dear.'

6



Bake When You Can

Flour, sugar and a little lard make a fine plain cookie. Restock the tin.

NOTES

A cookie broken in half is two cookies as far as a four-year-old is concerned.

IMPORTANT

Never hide the tin in the oven. Somebody will preheat it.

MATERIALS

- A cookie jar



- Two dozen cookies



- A small tin



- A high shelf



- A poker face



HOW TO

STORING WATER IN EVERY JAR IN THE HOUSE

SKILL 12 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

The man on the radio said to store water, and a good homemaker takes the radio at its word. Every jar, jug and pitcher in the house can hold a little. Line them up and the basement looks like a very wholesome laboratory.

MATERIALS


Clean glass jars

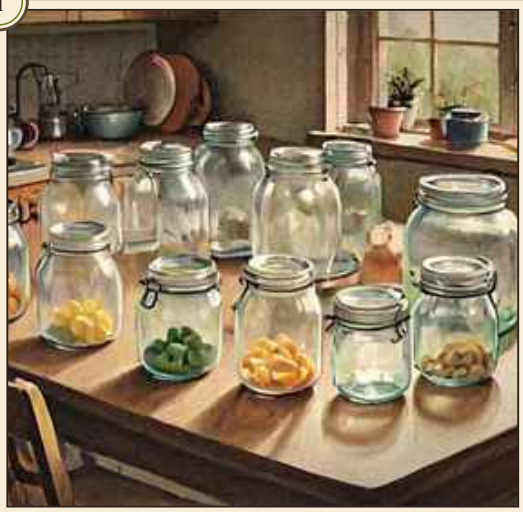

A big enamel pot


Wide-mouth jugs


A funnel


Masking tape

1



Gather Every Container

Pickle jars, mason jars, Grandmother's punch bowl. Anything clean with a lid.

2



Scrub Them Clean

Hot soapy water and a bottle brush. Rinse twice.

3



Fill Them Carefully

Pour slowly, or use a funnel. It is a lot of water to wipe off the floor otherwise.

4



Label the Date

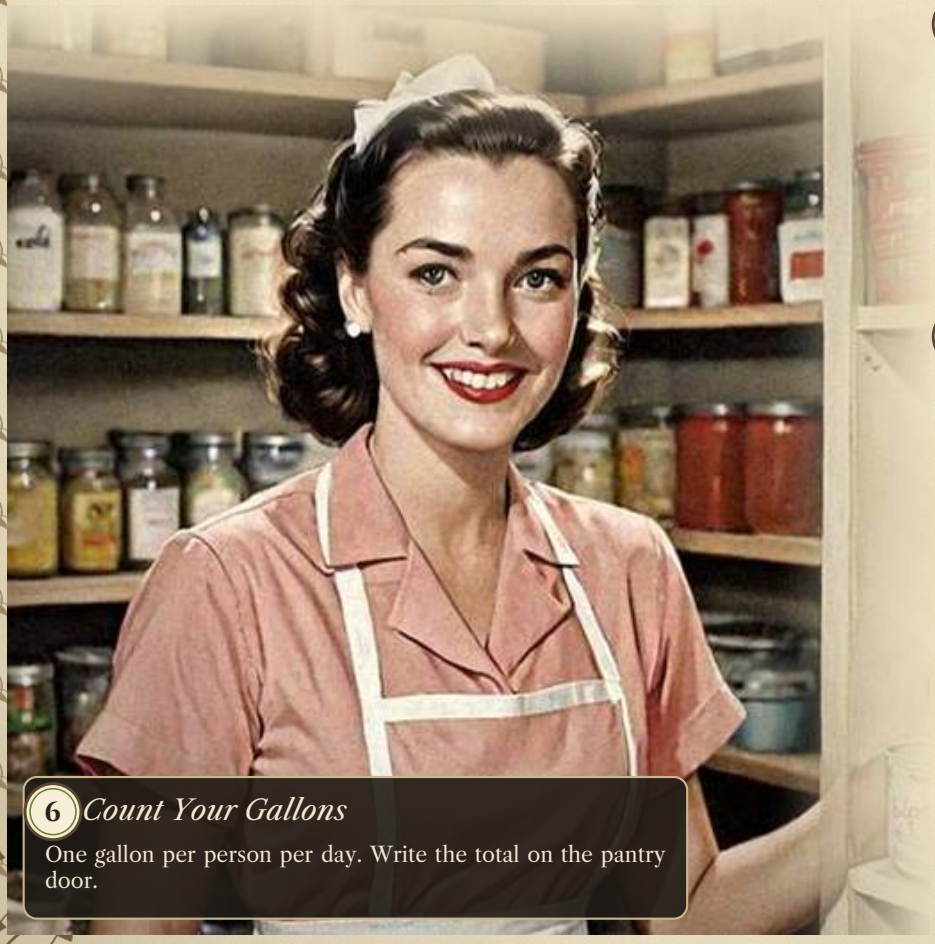
A strip of masking tape and the date. Change the water every few months.

5



Store Them Low

Low shelves, away from light. Water is heavy, and Father is not as young as he was.



6 ### *Count Your Gallons*

One gallon per person per day. Write the total on the pantry door.

NOTES

A full jug in the freezer helps keep the icebox cold when the power goes. Then you drink it.

IMPORTANT

Do not use the bathtub. The children will try to keep goldfish in it.

HOW TO

KEEPING THE PANTRY SAFE FROM MIDNIGHT SNACKERS

SKILL 13 · THE FALLOUT PANTRY · 1 EVENING · MEDIUM

Every family has a midnight snacker. In ours it is Father, Grandfather and, on alternate Tuesdays, the dog. When the pantry is all you have, a little vigilance goes a long way. Junior has volunteered as night watchman.

1



Hang a Bell on the Door

A small bell on a string announces anyone who comes calling.

2



Set Up Your Post

A chair by the pantry, a flashlight and something to read.

3

Stay Awake

Count cans. Recite the presidents. Do not eat your own sandwich too early.



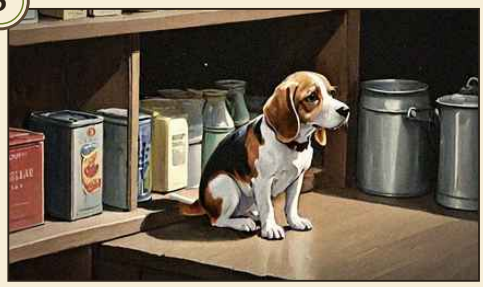
4



Listen for the Bell

Ting! Shine the flashlight, firmly.

5



Identify the Culprit

If it has a tail, it is the dog. If it has a mustache, it is Grandfather.

6



Report at Breakfast

Give your report to Mother. Names, times, items taken.

NOTES

A note on the pantry door that says 'Mother has counted these' works almost as well as a night watchman.

IMPORTANT

Do not lock Grandfather in the pantry. Even if he started it.

MATERIALS

- A flashlight



- A bell on a string



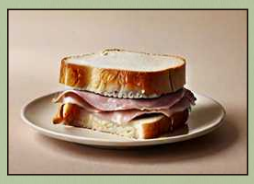
- A chair by the door



- A blanket



- A sandwich (for the watchman)



CHAPTER THREE

3

RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE

Cheerful cooking from the fallout pantry







Anyone can cook when the grocery is open. It takes a real homemaker to put a Sunday dinner on the table out of three cans, a box of crackers and a meteorite. The recipes in this chapter were tested in our own kitchen, on a camp stove, by candlelight, during aftershocks. Every one of them was eaten. Most of them were enjoyed.

IN THIS CHAPTER

14 The Mystery-Can Casserole
15 Biscuits Baked on a Warm Meteorite
16 Mock Apple Pie (No Apples Since Tuesday)
17 Sunday Roast on the Camp Stove
18 Luncheon Meat Fritters for Company
19 Crater Cake (It's Supposed to Sink)
20 A Gelatin Salad That Survives the Tremors

HOW TO

THE MYSTERY-CAN CASSEROLE

SKILL 14 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 1 HOUR · EASY

Every pantry has three cans nobody wants. Together, with a crunchy topping and a confident attitude, they become a casserole. This one has fed the family, the Civil Defense warden and two visiting scientists, and nobody has asked what is in it.

1



Open Three Cans

Choose one meat, one vegetable, one 'other'. Do not overthink it.

2



Stir in the Soup

Cream of mushroom holds everything together, like a good marriage.

3



Spread It in the Dish

Smooth the top with the back of a spoon.

MATERIALS


Three cans (any)


A can of cream soup


A casserole dish


Crushed crackers


A sprig of parsley

4



Top It With Crumbs

Crushed crackers and a dot of butter. The crunch distracts from the mystery.

5



Bake Until Bubbling

Thirty minutes, or until the edges bubble and the warden knocks.

NOTES

If anyone asks what is in it, say 'A little of this and a little of that.' It is true.

IMPORTANT

Never use more than one can of sardines. We learned this the hard way.



6 ### *Add Parsley and Smile*

Parsley makes anything a dinner. Serve with confidence.

HOW TO

BISCUITS BAKED ON A WARM METEORITE

SKILL 15 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 45 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A batch of biscuit dough



- A cast-iron skillet



- Oven mitts



- A rolling pin



- A tea towel



A piece of the asteroid landed on the back step. It is about the size of a pumpkin, it glows a gentle green and it stays as warm as an oven set to 350. The man from the university says it is perfectly harmless. The children call it Rocky. We bake on it.

1



Admire Rocky

Say good morning to the meteorite. It does not answer, but it is polite to ask.

2



Roll Out the Dough

Half an inch thick, floured board, gentle hands.

3

Cut the Biscuits

Neat rounds, close together. Use a drinking glass if the cutter is lost. It is always lost.



4



Set the Skillet on Rocky

Oven mitts on. Rocky is warm and the skillet will be warmer.

5



Bake Twenty Minutes

Turn the skillet halfway. Rocky is hotter on the side facing the garage.

6



Serve Warm

Butter, honey and a little prayer of thanks for small mercies.

NOTES

Rocky also keeps a teakettle at a steady simmer. Leave one on him all day.

IMPORTANT

Do not lick Rocky. The university man was very clear about this, and Junior has been told twice.

HOW TO

MOCK APPLE PIE (NO APPLES SINCE TUESDAY)

SKILL 16 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

Grandmother made this pie during the Depression and is delighted to be asked again. It contains no apples whatsoever, only crackers, sugar and lemon, and it tastes exactly like apple pie. Nobody understands how. Do not ask Grandmother; she just winks.

1



Make the Syrup

Sugar, water and a little cream of tartar, boiled until clear.

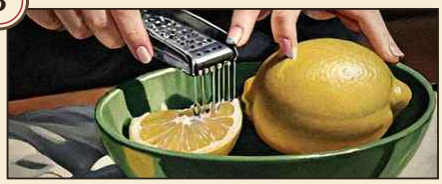
2



Break the Crackers

Break them into the pie shell by hand, in big pieces. Do not crush them.

3



Add the Lemon

Juice and grated rind. This is where the apple taste comes from. Somehow.

MATERIALS


A box of soda crackers


Two cups of sugar


A lemon


A pie crust


Cinnamon

4



Pour Over the Syrup

Hot syrup over the crackers, then a good shake of cinnamon.

5



Put the Lid On

Top crust, crimp the edges, cut three little vents.

NOTES

A scoop of vanilla ice cream makes it more convincing, if anyone on the street still has a working freezer.

IMPORTANT

Never tell the guests until after the second helping. It spoils the magic.



6 ### *Watch Them Guess*

Serve it warm. Wait. Enjoy the look on Father's face when you tell him.

HOW TO

SUNDAY ROAST ON THE CAMP STOVE

SKILL 17 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 3 HOURS · HARD

There is no power, the oven is cold and it is Sunday. Father has decided that this is a job for a man and a camp stove. Mother has decided to let him, and to have sandwiches ready just in case.

MATERIALS

- A camp stove



- A Dutch oven



- A canned ham



- Canned potatoes



- Long tongs



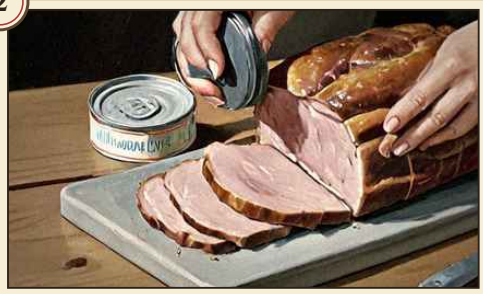
1



Light the Stove

Outside, on the back step. Father wears his apron. He insists it is a 'chef's coat'.

2



Open the Ham

A canned ham slides out in one piece if you open both ends.

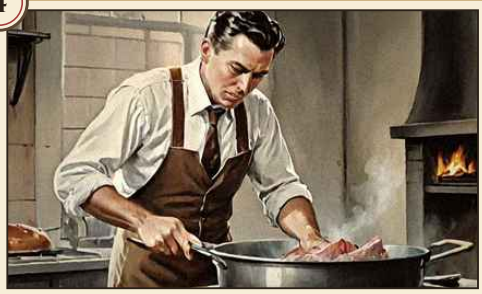
3

Into the Dutch Oven

Ham in the middle, potatoes around, lid on tight.



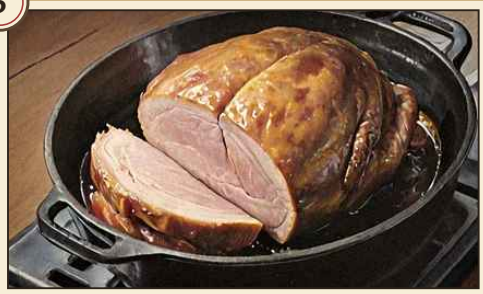
4



Turn It Now and Then

Every half hour, with long tongs and a serious expression.

5



Glaze It

Brown sugar and mustard in the last half hour. This is what makes it a roast.

6



Carve at the Table

Carving is Father's moment. Let him have it.

NOTES

If the ham is still cold in the middle after three hours, slice it thin and fry it. Nobody will know.

IMPORTANT

Keep Grandfather away from the camp stove. He 'helps' with the valve.

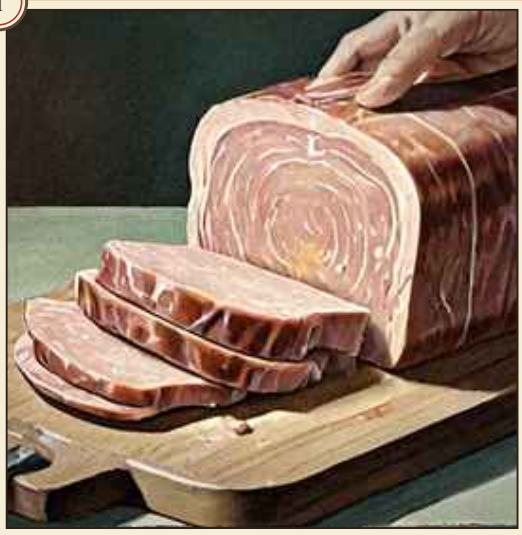
HOW TO

LUNCHEON MEAT FRITTERS FOR COMPANY

SKILL 18 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 30 MINUTES · EASY

The scientists from the university are coming to lunch, and all we have is canned luncheon meat. Sliced, dipped in batter and fried golden, it is a dish fit for a professor. Serve on the good china and call it by its fancy name: fritters.

1



Slice the Meat

Quarter-inch slices. Neat and even. Company is coming.

2



Mix the Batter

Pancake batter, a little thicker than for pancakes.

3



Dip Each Slice

Coat both sides. Let the extra drip off.

MATERIALS


A can of luncheon meat


Pancake batter


A frying pan


Shortening


The good china

4



Fry Until Golden

Hot shortening, two minutes a side. Do not crowd the pan.

5



Drain on Paper

A brown grocery bag does nicely.

NOTES

Leftover fritters are excellent cold in sandwiches the next day. If there are leftover fritters, which there will not be.

IMPORTANT

Do not tell the scientists it came from a can until they have asked for the recipe.



6 *Serve on the Good China*

Pineapple rings, a sprig of parsley, the good plate. Voila.

HOW TO

CRATER CAKE (IT'S SUPPOSED TO SINK)

SKILL 19 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 1 HOUR · EASY

Every cake baked during an aftershock sinks in the middle. Rather than cry over it, our daughter had a stroke of genius: fill the hole with chocolate and call it a Crater Cake. It is now the most requested dessert on Elm Street.

MATERIALS

- A box of cake mix



- A bundt ring pan



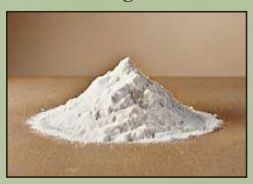
- Chocolate frosting



- A bag of chocolate chips



- Powdered sugar



1



Mix the Batter

Follow the box. Stir a hundred times. Count out loud.

2



Bake It

Bake as usual. Feel free to stamp your foot near the oven at the halfway point.

3

Let It Sink

Use the ring pan. Out comes the cake with a lovely hole in the middle, ready-made. Perfect.



4



Fill the Crater

Spoon in chocolate frosting until the crater is full to the rim.

5



Let It Drip

Pour the rest of the chocolate over the top and let it run down the sides like lava.

6



Dust With Ash

A sifting of powdered sugar. Very realistic. Very delicious.

NOTES

Green sprinkles around the rim look like the grass growing back. Optional, but the children insist.

IMPORTANT

Do not serve Crater Cake to the Civil Defense warden. He takes it personally.

HOW TO

A GELATIN SALAD THAT SURVIVES THE TREMORS

SKILL 20 · RECIPES FOR THE CRATER AGE · 4 HOURS · HARD

Little tremors have been rattling the house since Tuesday. They are harmless, but they are murder on a gelatin salad. With an extra packet of gelatin and the right mold, you can make a salad that wobbles bravely through anything.

1



Double the Gelatin

One packet for the flavor, one for the backbone.

2



Dissolve and Cool

Hot water first, then cold. Stir until no grains are left.

3



Add the Fruit

Fruit cocktail, well drained. The cherries go on the bottom of the mold.

MATERIALS


Two packets of lime gelatin


A packet of plain gelatin


A ring mold


Canned fruit cocktail


A serving plate

4



Chill in the Coldest Spot

The root cellar is cold and steady. Four hours at least.

5



Unmold Bravely

Dip the mold in warm water, plate on top, flip. Hold your breath.

NOTES

If it does collapse, spoon it into glasses, top with whipped cream and call it a parfait.

IMPORTANT

Never set a gelatin salad near Rocky. It will be soup in four minutes.



6 ### *Watch It Wobble*

When the next tremor comes, it will wiggle and hold. Applause.

CHAPTER FOUR

4

KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST

Cleaning, washing and ironing when the whole world needs a wipe







The asteroid did not just make a hole. It made dust. Fine gray space dust, on everything, every day, for weeks. A lesser homemaker would give up and let the house go. Not you. You have a feather duster, a good vacuum cleaner, a roll of tape and a sunny disposition. The dust has met its match.

IN THIS CHAPTER

21 Dusting When Everything Is Dust
22 Hanging Out the Wash Under an Orange Sky
23 Sealing the Windows With Tape and a Smile
24 Vacuuming the Ash Out of the Rug
25 Choosing Curtains to Hide the Crater View
26 A Mat for Every Door (and Shoes Off, Father)
27 Ironing Without Electricity

HOW TO

DUSTING WHEN EVERYTHING IS DUST

SKILL 21 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 1 MORNING · MEDIUM

When there is dust on the dust, a homemaker needs a system. Top to bottom, left to right, one room at a time, with a song on the radio and a damp cloth in her pocket. Remember: the dust does not win. It just keeps trying.

1



Start at the Top

Dust falls down. Begin with the light fixtures and work toward the floor.

2



Damp Your Cloth

A dry cloth just moves dust around. A damp one catches it.

3

Do the Picture Frames

Wedding photo first. It is the one Father looks at.



4



Mind the Knick-Knacks

Lift each china figure, dust under, put it back facing the same way.

5



Shake Out the Duster

Outside, downwind, away from the laundry.

6



Admire a Clean Room

Quickly, before more drifts in.

NOTES

Sing while you dust. A brisk tune keeps the arm moving, and the dust hates Sousa.

IMPORTANT

Do not dust Rocky. He gets warmer when fussed over and has scorched two cloths already.

MATERIALS

- A feather duster



- Soft cotton cloths



- A spray bottle of water



- A step stool



- A cheerful song



HOW TO

HANGING OUT THE WASH UNDER AN ORANGE SKY

SKILL 22 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 1 MORNING · MEDIUM

Monday is wash day, asteroid or no asteroid. The sky is a funny orange and there is a little ash in the air, so timing is everything. Watch the wind, pin quickly and bring it all in before it turns gray.

MATERIALS


A wringer washing machine


A basket of wet laundry


Wooden clothespins


A clothesline


A weather eye

1



Check the Wind

Lick a finger and hold it up. If the wind is from the crater, wait an hour.

2



Wring It Well

The drier it goes out, the faster it comes in.

3



Pin It Quickly

Sheets first, then shirts, then the small things.

4



Watch the Sky

If the orange turns gray, bring it all in. Do not finish your coffee first.

5



Bring It In Fast

Unpin into the basket without folding. Fold indoors.



6 ### *Shake Before Folding*

A good snap removes what the wind added.

NOTES

On very dusty days, string a line across the basement. It is not as nice, but it is clean.

IMPORTANT

Do not hang Father's white shirts on a gray day. He will go to work looking like a zebra.

HOW TO

SEALING THE WINDOWS WITH TAPE AND A SMILE

SKILL 23 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

The man from Civil Defense says to tape around the windows to keep the dust out. Father has volunteered. Mother has supervised. The result is a house that looks like a very neat present.

1



Wipe the Frames

Tape will not stick to dust. Wipe each frame and let it dry.

2



Measure the Strips

Cut each strip a little long. You can always trim.

3

Tape the Edges

Press firmly, smooth from the middle out. No wrinkles.



4



Check From Outside

Step out and look the windows over. Every pane should be neatly sealed, like a wrapped birthday gift.

5



Climb for the High Ones

Step ladder, both feet, Mother holding it steady.

6



Stand Back and Admire

Father will want a compliment. Give him one.

NOTES

Leave one window in each room untaped so you can still open it on a clear day.

IMPORTANT

Do not let Father tape the cat's door shut. The cat did not care for it at all.

MATERIALS

- A roll of wide tape



- A pair of scissors



- A step ladder



- A damp cloth



- A level eye



HOW TO

VACUUMING THE ASH OUT OF THE RUG

SKILL 24 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

Every footstep brings in a little more of the asteroid. The good rug has gone from rose pink to battleship gray. A canister vacuum, a stiff brush and a firm hand will bring it back.

MATERIALS


A canister vacuum cleaner


A stiff brush


A rug beater


Spare dust bags


A washing line

1



Move the Furniture

Coffee table, footstool and Father, all to the side.

2



Brush Up the Pile

A stiff brush loosens what the vacuum cannot reach.

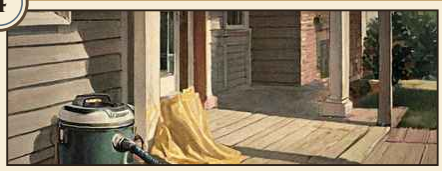
3



Vacuum Slowly

Slow strokes, overlapping. A fast vacuum is just a noise.

4



Change the Bag Often

A full bag just blows it back. Change it outdoors.

5



Air It in the Yard

Once a week, carry the rug out into the sunshine and give it a good beating.



6 ### *Enjoy the Pink*

There it is. Rose pink again. Until Tuesday.

NOTES

A sprinkle of damp tea leaves on the rug before you vacuum catches the fine dust. Grandmother swears by it.

IMPORTANT

Do not vacuum near Rocky. The vacuum will try to swallow him and that is a long story.

HOW TO

CHOOSING CURTAINS TO HIDE THE CRATER VIEW

SKILL 25 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

The kitchen window used to look out on roses. Now it looks out on a crater. A crater is interesting for the first few days and then it is just a hole. Grandmother has a solution: cheerful curtains, and plenty of them.

1



Measure the Window

Width twice over, so they gather nicely. Length to the sill.

2



Choose a Cheerful Print

Red gingham. Nothing says 'everything is fine' like red gingham.

3

Sew the Hems

A straight hem on the treadle. Slow and steady.



4



Thread the Rod

Rings on, rod up, done.

5



Hang Them Up

Up they go. Instantly the kitchen is the kitchen again.

6



Peek Out Now and Then

Just to check the crater is still there. It always is.

NOTES

Make a matching tablecloth from the leftover fabric. Then the curtains look planned.

IMPORTANT

Do not make the curtains from the tablecloth. Then you have no tablecloth.

MATERIALS

- Gingham fabric



- A sewing machine



- Curtain rod and rings



- Pins and thread



- A tape measure



HOW TO

A MAT FOR EVERY DOOR (AND SHOES OFF, FATHER)

SKILL 26 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 15 MINUTES · EASY

Most of the asteroid comes into the house on the bottom of somebody's shoes, and that somebody is usually Father. A mat at every door, a bench for sitting and a firm house rule will save hours of sweeping.

MATERIALS


Coir doormats


A shoe rack


A small bench


A pair of slippers for everyone


A firm voice

1



Lay a Mat Outside

A rough coir mat outside each door scrapes off the worst.

2



And One Inside

A soft rag rug inside catches the rest.

3



Set Up a Shoe Bench

A bench and a rack by the back door. Shoes off, slippers on.

4



Line Up the Slippers

One pair for everyone, toes pointing out, ready to go.

5



Remind Father

Every time. With a smile. He will learn by Christmas.



6 ### *Check the Porch Daily*

Every morning, before the coffee, step out and shake out whatever needs it.

NOTES

A boot scraper by the steps saves the mat. Grandfather made ours from an old horseshoe.

IMPORTANT

The dog will not take his shoes off. Wipe his paws with a damp towel instead.

HOW TO

IRONING WITHOUT ELECTRICITY

SKILL 27 · KEEPING HOUSE IN THE DUST · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

The electric iron is useless without electricity, but Grandmother still has her old sad irons, the heavy kind you heat on the stove. She ironed for nine children with them and she is delighted to be useful again.

1



Heat the Stove

Fire up the old wood stove, or use Rocky. Two irons go on top; one heats while you use the other.

2



Dampen the Shirts

Sprinkle, roll up and wait ten minutes.

3

Test on a Cloth

Always test first. A scorched collar is forever.



4



Iron Collar First

Collar, cuffs, sleeves, back, front. In that order. Always.

5



Swap the Irons

When it cools, swap it for the hot one. Keep a rhythm.

6



Hang Them Crisp

Straight onto hangers. Father will look like an executive again.

NOTES

A sad iron stays hot for about five minutes. That is exactly one shirt, if you do not chat.

IMPORTANT

Always use the wooden handle or a thick holder. Grandmother's hands are made of leather. Yours are not.

MATERIALS

- Two old sad irons



- A camp stove or a warm meteorite



- An ironing board



- A sprinkling bottle



- A pressing cloth



CHAPTER FIVE

5

THE BACKYARD CRATER

Making the most of a very large hole







Most families have a backyard. We have a backyard with a crater in it, forty feet across, ten feet deep and still faintly warm. At first it was a shock. Then it was a nuisance. Now it is the most talked-about yard on Elm Street. This chapter is about making peace with your crater and then making it lovely.

IN THIS CHAPTER

28 Putting a Nice Fence Around the Crater
29 Growing Tomatoes in Crater Soil
30 Living With a Glowing Space Rock
31 A Picnic on the Crater Rim
32 Hosting the Scientists Who Came to Look
33 Turning the Crater Into a Duck Pond

HOW TO

PUTTING A NICE FENCE AROUND THE CRATER

SKILL 28 · THE BACKYARD CRATER · 1 WEEKEND · MEDIUM

A crater without a fence is a hazard. A crater with a white picket fence is a feature. Father spent one Saturday on this, with Junior holding the nails, and the Garden Club has already been round twice to look.

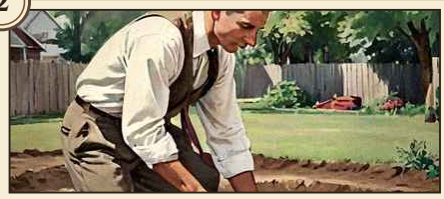
1



Mark the Line

String and stakes, three paces back from the edge. Never closer.

2



Dig the Post Holes

Every eight feet. The soil is soft and a little warm.

3



Set the Posts

Straight and firm. Check each one by eye and by level.

MATERIALS


White fence pickets


A hammer and nails


A ball of string


A can of white paint


A paintbrush

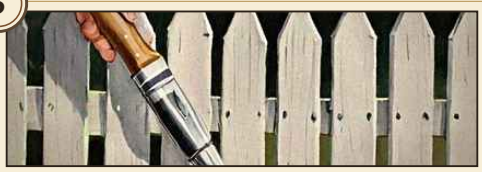
4



Nail On the Pickets

Use a spare picket as a spacer. Neat gaps make a neat fence.

5



Paint It White

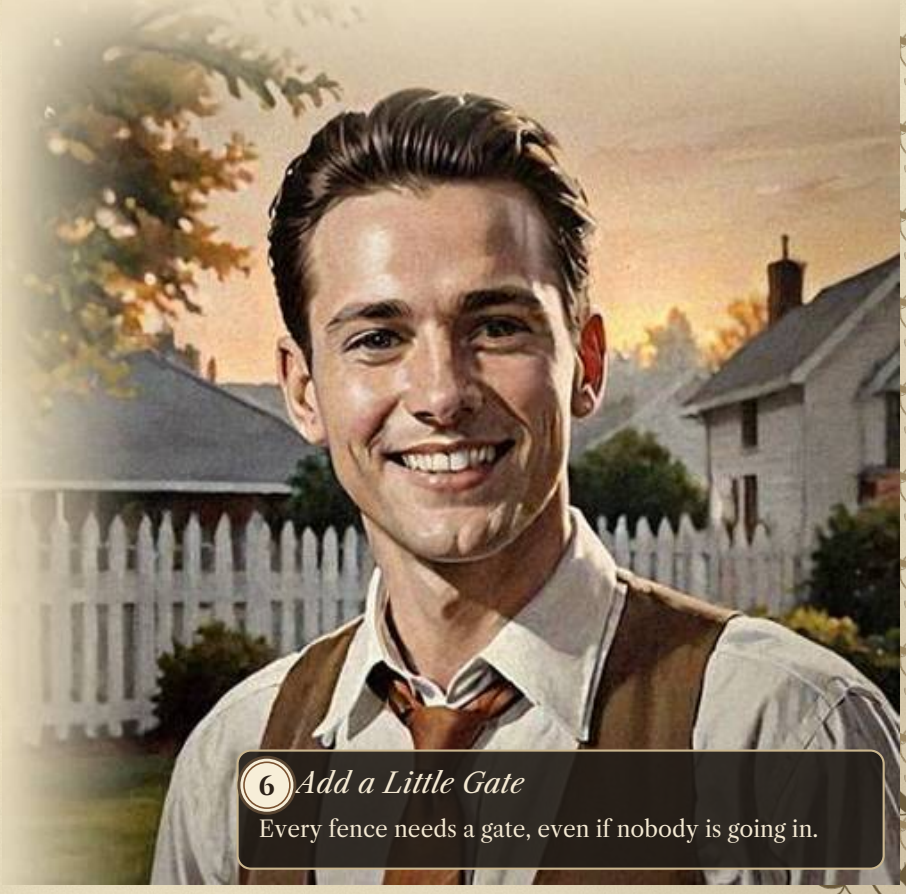
Two coats. The crater will look positively Colonial.

NOTES

Plant hollyhocks along the fence. In a year, nobody will be able to see the crater at all.

IMPORTANT

Do not lean on the fence to admire the view until the posts have settled. Father did.



6 *Add a Little Gate*

Every fence needs a gate, even if nobody is going in.

HOW TO

GROWING TOMATOES IN CRATER SOIL

SKILL 29 · THE BACKYARD CRATER · 1 SUMMER · EASY

Something in the asteroid has done wonders for the soil around the crater. Grandfather planted his usual tomatoes, and they are now the size of beach balls. Growing them is easy. Getting them into the kitchen takes two men and a wheelbarrow.

MATERIALS

- Tomato seedlings



- Tall wooden stakes



- Garden twine



- A watering can



- A wheelbarrow



1



Plant Near the Rim

Just inside the fence, where the soil is warmest.

2



Stake Them Tall

Very tall. Taller than you think. Taller than that.

3

Water Every Morning

The crater soil drinks a lot. So do the tomatoes.



4



Watch Them Grow

Then watch them grow some more. Measure weekly for the Garden Club.

5



Harvest With Help

Cut the stem, catch it in a blanket, roll it to the wheelbarrow.

6



Share With the Street

One tomato makes forty sandwiches. Ring the neighbors.

NOTES

A single giant tomato makes enough sauce to fill every jar in the house. Plan your canning day accordingly.

IMPORTANT

Never leave a ripe one on the slope. It will roll into the crater and you will need the ladder again.

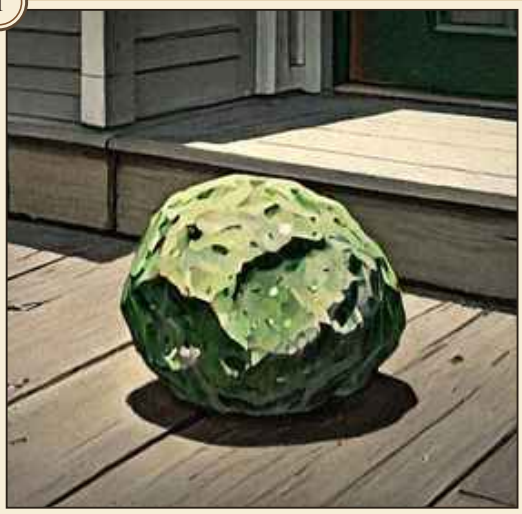
HOW TO

LIVING WITH A GLOWING SPACE ROCK

SKILL 30 · THE BACKYARD CRATER · ONGOING · MEDIUM

Rocky the meteorite lives on the back step now. He glows a gentle green, he hums a little in the evening and he keeps the porch toasty. The man from the university says he is perfectly harmless, but has asked us to keep a few simple rules.

1



Give Him a Spot

On the back step, on a mat, out of the rain. Every rock deserves a home.

2



Say Good Night

Rocky glows brighter at bedtime. It is very soothing. Say good night.

3



No Licking

This is rule number one. It is rule number one for a reason.

MATERIALS


A glowing meteorite (Rocky)


A doormat for Rocky to sit on


Long marshmallow sticks


A blanket


A rule list

4



Give Him a Polish

A soft cloth once a week. Rocky shines up lovely, and he seems to enjoy it.

5



Keep Your Feet Warm

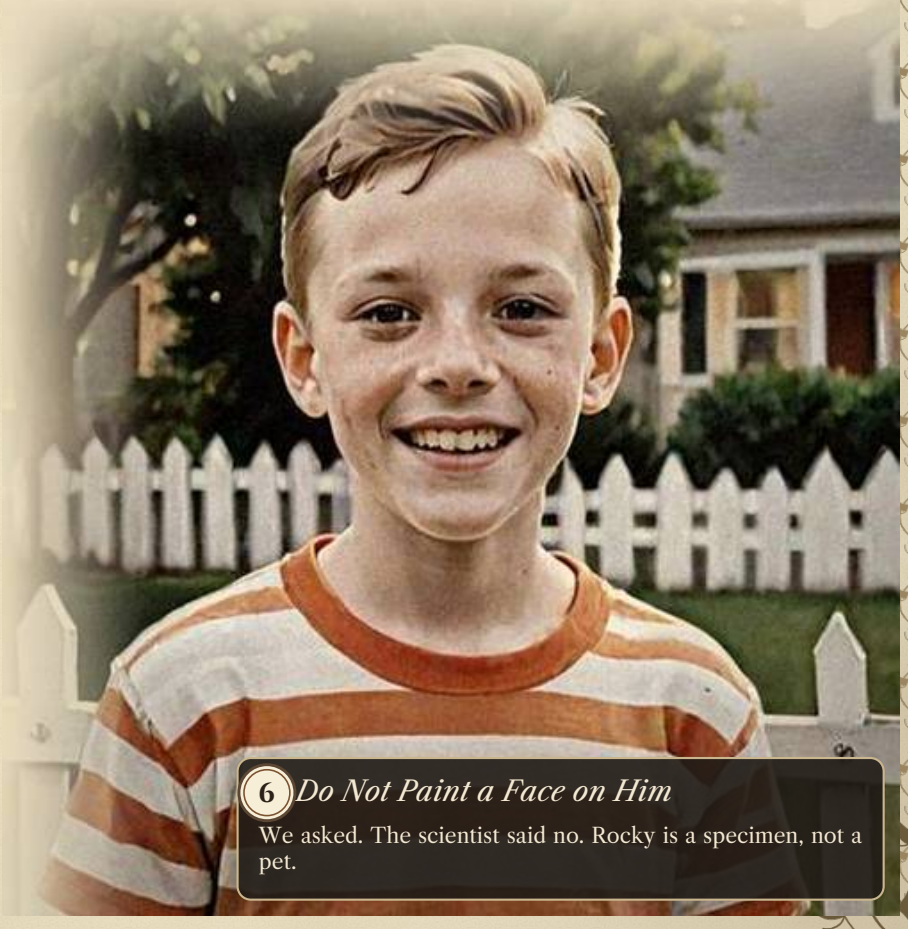
A blanket and a chair beside Rocky beats any fireplace.

NOTES

Rocky toasts a marshmallow a perfect golden brown. Use a long stick and keep an arm's length. The children have never been so willing to sit on the porch.

IMPORTANT

Do not let the dog bury Rocky. We spent all of Thursday digging.



6 *Do Not Paint a Face on Him*

We asked. The scientist said no. Rocky is a specimen, not a pet.

HOW TO

A PICNIC ON THE CRATER RIM

SKILL 31 · THE BACKYARD CRATER · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

Once the fence is up and the dust has settled, the crater rim is the finest picnic spot in town. There is a view, a gentle warmth from the ground and nobody can say the Hendersons have anything like it.

MATERIALS

- A picnic basket



- A checkered blanket



- Deviled eggs



- A thermos of lemonade



- Paper plates



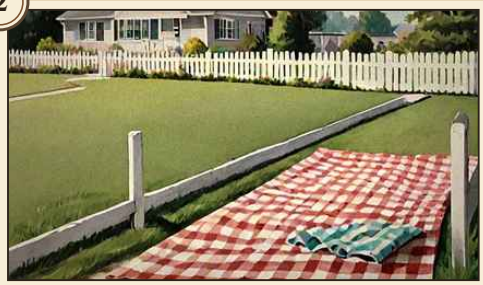
1



Pack the Basket

Deviled eggs, sandwiches, a cake, lemonade. Napkins. Always napkins.

2



Pick a Flat Spot

Inside the fence, well back from the edge, with a nice view.

3

Spread the Blanket

Shake it out, lay it down, put a rock on each corner.



4



Lay Out the Food

Eggs in the middle, everything else around. Like a clock.

5



Enjoy the View

Point out the interesting layers in the crater wall. Children love geology.

6



Pack Out Everything

Leave the crater as you found it. Except tidier.

NOTES

The rim is always a few degrees warmer than the lawn, so it is perfect for an early spring picnic.

IMPORTANT

Never roll hard-boiled eggs down the crater for fun. We still have not found three of them.

HOW TO

HOSTING THE SCIENTISTS WHO CAME TO LOOK

SKILL 32 · THE BACKYARD CRATER · 1 WEEK · MEDIUM

Two days after the impact, three scientists from the university arrived in a station wagon, set up a tent by the crater and have been measuring things ever since. They are very polite young men. They are also very hungry. A good hostess makes the best of it.

1



Welcome Them Warmly

They are guests, even if nobody invited them.

2



Set Up a Lemonade Table

A folding table at the fence. Scientists get thirsty when measuring.

3



Serve Lunch at Noon

Sandwiches on a tray, sharp at twelve. They lose track of time.

MATERIALS



A pitcher of lemonade



A plate of sandwiches



A folding table



A spare blanket



Patience for long words

4



Listen Politely

Nod at 'chondrite'. Smile at 'ejecta'. Ask if they would like more pie.

5



Keep Them Out of the Kitchen

They want to test Rocky in the oven. Say no.

NOTES

Scientists will eat anything if you tell them it is an experiment.

IMPORTANT

Do not let them take Rocky. He is family now, and the children will not stand for it.



6 *Wave Them Off*

When they leave, wave the station wagon down the street. They will write.

HOW TO

TURNING THE CRATER INTO A DUCK POND

SKILL 33 · THE BACKYARD CRATER · 1 SEASON · HARD

MATERIALS

- A pair of rubber boots



- Water lily plants



- Wooden planks for a dock



- A sack of duck feed



- A garden bench



After the first good rain, the crater filled with water. Father looked at it for a long time. Then he said, 'Ducks.' Now we have a pond, a little dock, three ducks and the envy of the entire Garden Club.

1



Let It Fill

Wait for rain. The crater does the rest.

2



Plant Lilies

Water lilies in pots at the shallow end. Boots on.

3

Build a Little Dock

Four planks and two posts. Nothing fancy. Ducks are not fussy.



4



Invite the Ducks

A handful of feed every morning. They will find you.

5



Add a Bench

Every pond deserves somewhere to sit and think.

6



Enjoy the Evening

Sit on the bench at sunset. Say 'Ducks' to yourself. Smile.

NOTES

Goldfish from the dime store do very well in crater ponds. Ours are now the size of trout.

IMPORTANT

Do not let the children skate on it in winter until Father has tested the ice with a long pole.

CHAPTER SIX

6

THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND

Making the basement shelter cozy, cheerful and full of board games







When the aftershocks rumble or the pebble showers start, the family heads down to the basement shelter. A shelter can be a damp, gloomy cellar, or it can be the coziest room in the house. With a rag rug, a few lamps, a stack of board games and a little imagination, ours has become the place the children want to be.

IN THIS CHAPTER

34 Making the Shelter Feel Like Home
35 Board Games by Lantern Light
36 Bedtime in the Bunk Beds
37 Duck and Cover Drills Everyone Enjoys
38 Keeping Grandmother Busy in Close Quarters
39 Explaining the Situation to the Dog

HOW TO

MAKING THE SHELTER FEEL LIKE HOME

SKILL 34 · THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND · 1 WEEKEND · MEDIUM

A basement shelter is four concrete walls and a lot of potential. Rugs, lamps, curtains and a picture or two make all the difference. If you would not be ashamed to have the bridge club down there, you have done it right.

MATERIALS


A braided rag rug


Two oil lamps


A painted landscape


Gingham curtains


A vase of paper flowers

1



Sweep It Out

Cobwebs down, floor swept, Father's old fishing tackle up to the garage.

2



Lay a Rug

A braided rug on concrete is like a hug for the feet.

3



Hang a Picture

A painted landscape gives you a window where there is none.

4



Add a Pretend Window

Curtains on a bare wall. It sounds silly. It works.

5



Light the Lamps

Warm light, not a bare bulb. Bare bulbs are for interrogations.



6 *Arrange the Flowers*

Paper flowers last forever and need no sun.

NOTES

A wind-up gramophone and a few records turn a basement into a parlor.

IMPORTANT

Never put the good rug down there. Basements are damp, even cozy ones.

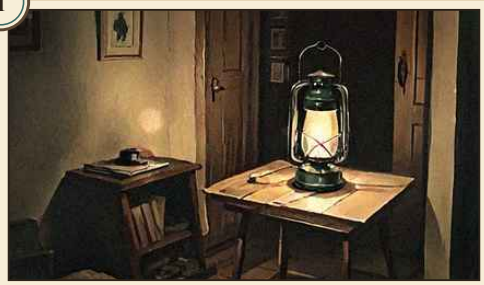
HOW TO

BOARD GAMES BY LANTERN LIGHT

SKILL 35 · THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND · 1 EVENING · EASY

When the pebbles are rattling on the roof and nobody can go out, it is time for the board games. Checkers, dominoes and a jigsaw puzzle of the Grand Canyon have kept our family happy through eleven pebble showers so far.

1



Set Up the Card Table

Folding table, folding chairs, lantern in the middle.

2



Pick a Game

Youngest picks first. It saves arguments.

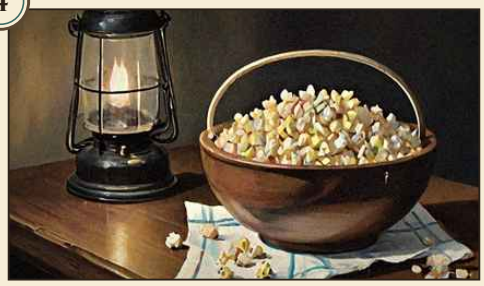
3

Play Checkers

King me! The two most exciting words in the English language.



4



Pass the Popcorn

One bowl, everyone shares. Butter optional.

5



Start a Jigsaw

Edges first. A big puzzle can last a whole aftershock season.

6



Win Gracefully

Shake hands. Do not do a dance. Grandfather does a dance.

NOTES

Keep a list on the wall of who won what. Our family checkers championship is now in its forty-first round.

IMPORTANT

Do not play Monopoly in a shelter. Nobody has ever been calm enough after Monopoly.

MATERIALS

- A checkerboard



- A box of dominoes



- A jigsaw puzzle



- A lantern



- A bowl of popcorn



HOW TO

BEDTIME IN THE BUNK BEDS

SKILL 36 · THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND · 30 MINUTES · EASY

On noisy nights, the whole family sleeps down in the shelter in bunk beds Father built from a kit. Bedtime is the same as upstairs: teeth, prayers, a story and a kiss. Only the ceiling is different.

MATERIALS


Wooden bunk beds


Warm quilts


A favorite storybook


A nightlight


Teddy bears

1



Make Up the Bunks

Clean sheets, warm quilt, one pillow each, turned down.

2



Brush Teeth

In a basin, with a jug. Two minutes, no splashing.

3



Tuck In Teddy

Teddy goes in first so the bed is warm.

4



Read a Story

Something gentle. Not about space.

5



Turn On the Nightlight

A small glow keeps the dark friendly.



6 *Kiss Good Night*

And one more for luck.

NOTES

Let the children decorate the underside of the top bunk with paper stars. It gives the bottom bunk something to look at.

IMPORTANT

Junior is not allowed on the top bunk after the Great Tumble of Thursday last.

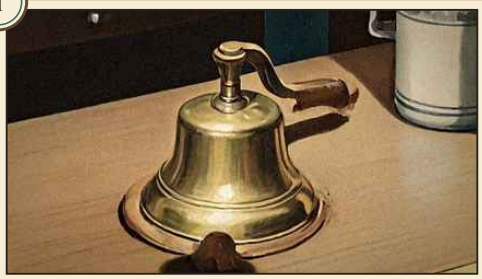
HOW TO

DUCK AND COVER DRILLS EVERYONE ENJOYS

SKILL 37 · THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND · 10 MINUTES · EASY

The Civil Defense man says families should practice ducking and covering, in case of pebble showers. Practice makes perfect, and with a bell, a stopwatch and a prize for the fastest, it is the most popular game in the house.

1



Ring the Bell

Keep the bell on the counter. Three rings means drill. Everybody stops what they are doing.

2



Duck

Down on the floor, knees tucked, quick as you can.

3

Cover

Hands over your head, then under the nearest table. The table is your umbrella.



4



Hold Still

Count to twenty. No giggling. Well, a little giggling.

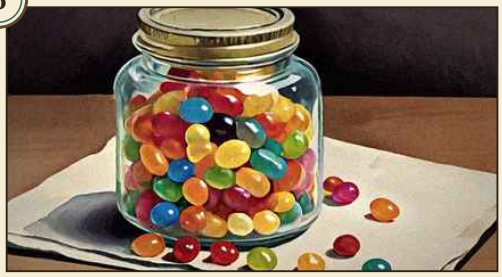
5



Check the Stopwatch

Fastest family member gets a gold star.

6



Hand Out Prizes

Jelly beans for all. Even for Father, who came last.

NOTES

Practice under every table in the house, so everyone knows which one is nearest.

IMPORTANT

Do not drill during dinner. The gravy suffers.

MATERIALS

- A brass hand bell



- A stopwatch



- A sturdy kitchen table



- A gold star chart



- A bag of jelly beans



HOW TO

KEEPING GRANDMOTHER BUSY IN CLOSE QUARTERS

SKILL 38 · THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND · ONGOING · MEDIUM

Grandmother has lived through two wars, a depression and an asteroid, and she is not about to sit still in a basement. Give her a project, or she will reorganize your spice rack, alphabetically, by Latin name.

MATERIALS


Knitting needles

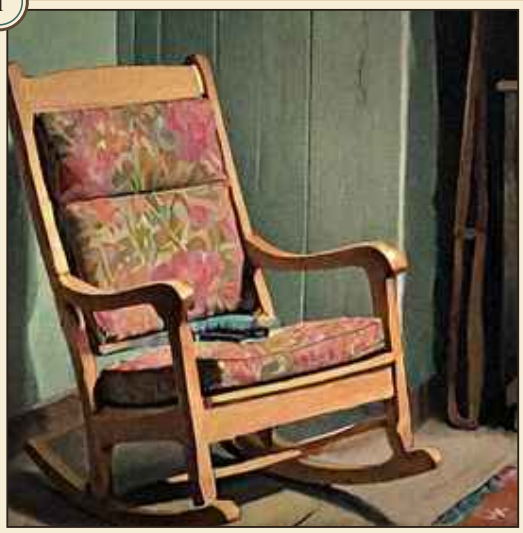

Balls of wool yarn


A quilting hoop


Fabric scraps


A rocking chair

1



Give Her a Rocking Chair

A good chair with a cushion is the foundation of everything.

2



Hand Her the Yarn

Every color you have. She will make sense of it.

3



Let Her Knit

Mittens, scarves, a sweater for the dog. Whatever she likes.

4



Start a Quilt

Scraps from the curtains, Father's old shirts, the tea towels.

5



Ask for Her Stories

She will tell you about the winter of 1912. Listen. It is a good one.



6 *Admire the Results*

By the end of the week, everyone has new mittens.

NOTES

Grandmother can knit in the dark. Do not ask how. Just be grateful.

IMPORTANT

Never let her start on Father's sock drawer. He has a system, apparently.

HOW TO

EXPLAINING THE SITUATION TO THE DOG

SKILL 39 · THE FAMILY UNDERGROUND · 15 MINUTES · EASY

Buster the beagle does not understand the asteroid. He barks at the crater, howls at the orange sky and has tried twice to bury Rocky. A boy's job is to sit down with his dog and explain things man to dog.

1



Sit With Him

On the back step, side by side. Eye level is respectful.

2



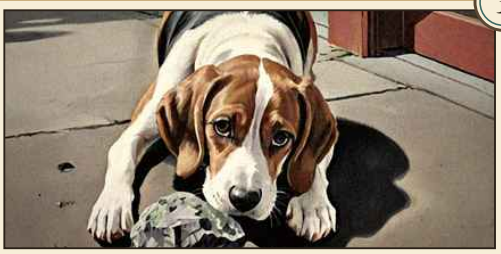
Point to the Crater

Explain slowly. 'That is a crater, Buster. It is not a rabbit hole.'

3

Show Him Rocky

Let him sniff Rocky from a polite distance. No digging.



4



Give a Biscuit

Every good explanation ends with a biscuit.

5



Play Fetch

A tired dog does not worry about asteroids.

6



Tuck Him In

His blanket, his basket, a pat on the head.

NOTES

Dogs understand tone better than words. Say everything as if it were good news.

IMPORTANT

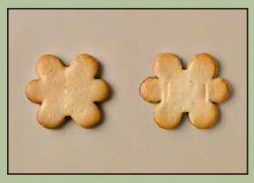
Never explain the asteroid to the cat. She does not care and will make that very clear.

MATERIALS

- A beagle (Buster)



- A box of dog biscuits



- His favorite blanket



- A rubber ball



- A lot of patience



CHAPTER SEVEN

7

OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD

Shopping, visiting and keeping up standards around town







Sooner or later, a homemaker must leave the house. The grocery has reopened, the beauty parlor is doing a roaring trade in head scarves and the church bake sale is going ahead, crater or no crater. Main Street looks a little dusty, but the people are the same as ever, only friendlier. This chapter keeps you looking your best and behaving your best wherever you go.

IN THIS CHAPTER

40 Shopping When the Grocer Takes Canned Goods
41 Wearing a Hat Against Falling Pebbles
42 The Church Bake Sale Goes On
43 Driving Around the Craters
44 Writing to Aunt Edna About the Asteroid
45 Making Friends With the Civil Defense Warden
46 Keeping Your Hairdo in a Dust Storm

HOW TO

SHOPPING WHEN THE GROCER TAKES CANNED GOODS

SKILL 40 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

Since the asteroid, Mr. Kowalski at the grocery has stopped trusting money and started trusting tins. A can of peaches buys a pound of butter. Two cans of soup buy a chicken. A homemaker who knows her exchange rates eats like a queen.

1



Check Your Trading Stock

Which cans can you spare? Never trade the cherries.

2



Walk to the Grocery

Head scarf on, bag over your arm, chin up.

3



Read the Board

Mr. Kowalski chalks up the day's rates by the door.

MATERIALS


A string shopping bag


A selection of canned goods


A grocery list


A small notebook


Your best smile

4



Make Your Offer

Put your cans on the counter and smile. Never look too keen on the chicken.

5



Haggle Politely

If he says three cans, say two and a smile. He usually takes it.

NOTES

Spam is worth twice what it was. Maraschino cherries are worth a fortune. Act accordingly.

IMPORTANT

Never try to pay in Rocky's crumbs. The university man says they are 'not legal tender, and also please give them to me'.



6 ### *Carry Home the Prize*

Butter, eggs and a chicken. A very good morning's trading.

HOW TO

WEARING A HAT AGAINST FALLING PEBBLES

SKILL 41 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · 5 MINUTES · EASY

Little space pebbles still fall now and then, about the size of peas. They are harmless, but they are bad for a hairdo. Every lady on Elm Street now wears a hat with a good firm brim, and the milliner on Main Street has never been busier.

MATERIALS

- A wide-brimmed straw hat



- A hat pin



- A sturdy umbrella



- A head scarf



- A hand mirror



1



Choose a Firm Brim

Straw with a stiff brim. Felt is fine in winter.

2



Pin It Securely

A good long hat pin through the crown and your hair. Two if it is windy.

3

Tilt It Just So

A slight tilt is elegant, and it sheds pebbles to one side.



4



Carry an Umbrella

For heavier showers. Tap the pebbles off before you come inside.

5



Listen for the Ping

A ping on the brim means walk a little faster.

6



Brush Off at the Door

A quick brush of the brim before you step in. Pebbles in the hall are a nuisance.

NOTES

Father's hard hat from the plant is very sensible, but do not let him wear it to church.

IMPORTANT

Do not look up with your mouth open during a pebble shower. Junior did, and he has stories now.

HOW TO

THE CHURCH BAKE SALE GOES ON

SKILL 42 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · 1 DAY · EASY

The ladies of First Methodist have held a bake sale every October since 1921, and a little thing like an asteroid will not stop them. This year's theme is 'Treats From the Pantry', and Grandmother's mock apple pie is the one to beat.

1



Bake Your Best

Bring the thing you are known for. Grandmother brings the pie.

2



Set Up the Table

White cloth, doilies, everything in neat rows.

3



Arrange the Treats

Tall cakes at the back, cookies at the front, pie in the middle.

MATERIALS


A mock apple pie


A long folding table


A white tablecloth


A cash box


Paper doilies

4



Mind the Cash Box

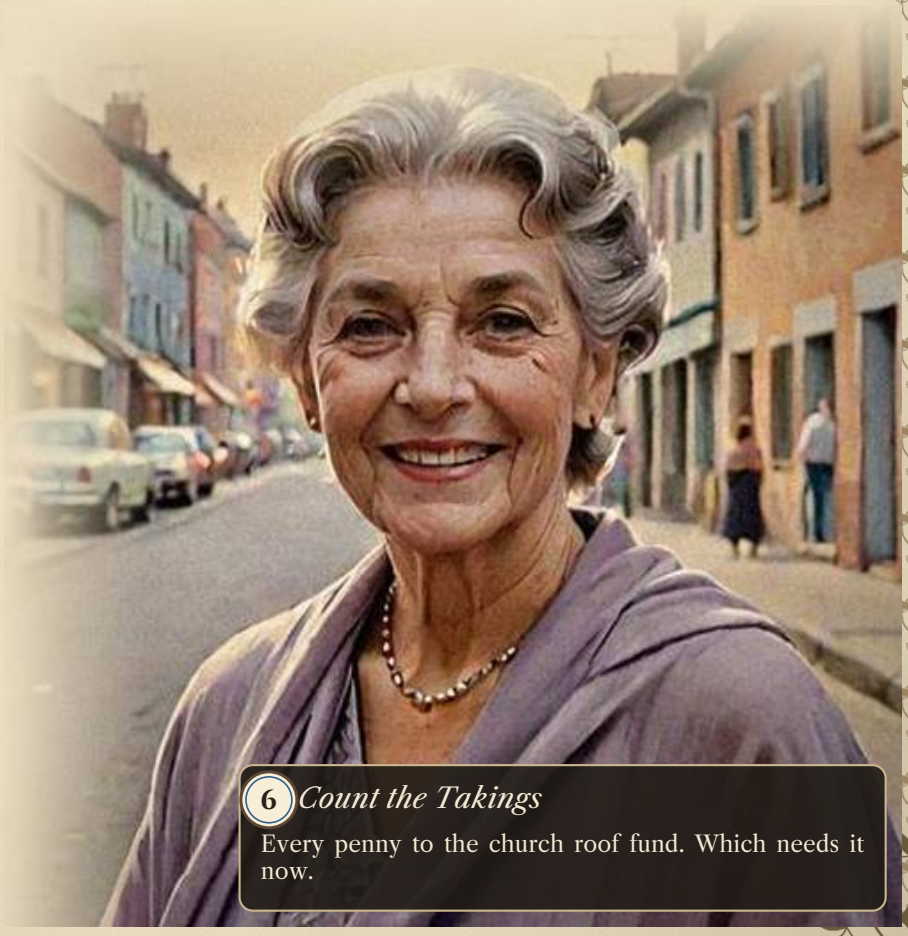
Make change carefully. Accept cans at the going rate.

5



Charm the Customers

'Try a sample, Reverend?' works every time.



6 ### *Count the Takings*

Every penny to the church roof fund. Which needs it now.

NOTES

Label everything clearly. After the asteroid, everyone wants to know what is in everything.

IMPORTANT

Do not sell Crater Cake next to Mrs. Henderson's angel food. It upsets her.

HOW TO

DRIVING AROUND THE CRATERS

SKILL 43 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Most of the road into town is fine, but there are a few new craters on Maple Avenue, two by the post office and a very big one where the drive-in used to be. Father has learned to drive the station wagon around them all, and he wants everyone to know it.

MATERIALS

- The family station wagon



- A paper road map



- A pencil



- A thermos of coffee



- Your Sunday driving gloves



1



Mark the Map

Draw a circle on the road map for every new crater you know about.

2



Check the Car

Dust off the windshield. Check the tires. Honk once for luck.

3

Drive Slowly

Twenty miles an hour, both hands on the wheel, no showing off.



4



Take the Long Way Round

Give every crater a wide berth. A crater is not a shortcut.

5



Watch for Detour Signs

The Civil Defense men put up sawhorses. Obey them.

6



Arrive Proudly

Park neatly. Mention the craters to everyone you meet.

NOTES

On foggy days, the craters are hard to see. Drive with the window down and listen for the ducks.

IMPORTANT

The drive-in crater is not a drive-in. Some teenagers had to learn this the hard way.

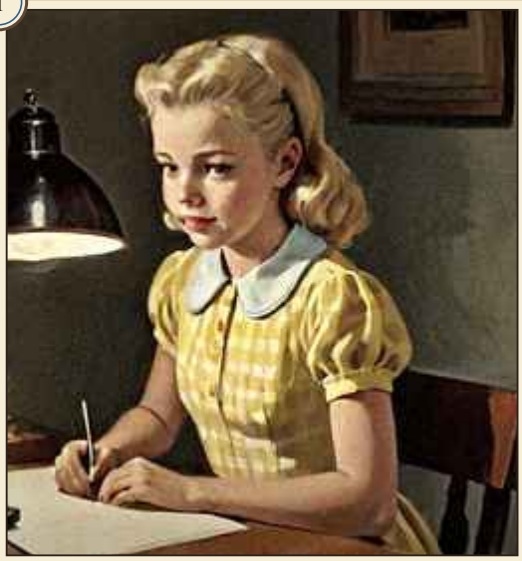
HOW TO

WRITING TO AUNT EDNA ABOUT THE ASTEROID

SKILL 44 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · 1 EVENING · EASY

Aunt Edna lives in Ohio, which was not hit by anything, and she is desperate for news. A good letter is cheerful, newsy and never alarming. Mother says it is the girl's job this week, and she has been practicing her joined-up writing.

1



Sit Somewhere Quiet

A tidy table, good light and no brothers.

2



Start Cheerfully

'Dear Aunt Edna, We are all very well, and we have a crater.'

3



Give the News

The fence, the ducks, Rocky. Leave out the bit about the drive-in.

MATERIALS


Nice notepaper


A fountain pen


An envelope


A three-cent stamp


A pressed flower

4



Describe the Pond

Tell her all about the crater pond and the ducks. Aunts love a good description.

5



Tuck In a Flower

A pressed pansy from the garden, to show things still grow.

NOTES

Ask Aunt Edna questions in your letter. Then she has to write back.

IMPORTANT

Do not send Aunt Edna a piece of Rocky. The post office has rules now.



6 *Stamp and Mail*

Stamp straight, top right corner. Walk it to the mailbox.

HOW TO

MAKING FRIENDS WITH THE CIVIL DEFENSE WARDEN

SKILL 45 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · ONGOING · EASY

Mr. Fenwick, the block warden, walks Elm Street twice a day in his white helmet and armband, checking that everyone is all right. He takes his job very seriously. He also takes his coffee with three sugars, which is the key to his heart.

MATERIALS

- A cup of coffee (three sugars)



- A plate of doughnuts



- A friendly wave



- The family list



- A porch chair



1



Wave When He Passes

A cheery wave every morning. He waves back, very officially.

2



Offer Coffee

Three sugars. Bring it to the gate. He cannot leave his rounds for long.

3

Give Him the Family List

Names and ages, typed. He loves a typed list.



4



Listen to His Rules

Nod at each one. Most are sensible. Some are about hats.

5



Admire His Armband

He polished the buckle. Notice it.

6



Invite Him for Supper

Once a month. He lives alone and he talks about it.

NOTES

A friendly warden will tell you first when the grocery gets a delivery. This is worth every doughnut.

IMPORTANT

Do not let the children borrow his whistle. Ever.

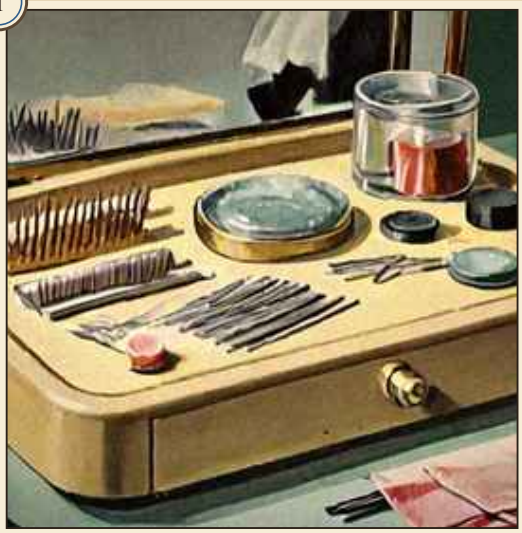
HOW TO

KEEPING YOUR HAIRDO IN A DUST STORM

SKILL 46 · OUT AND ABOUT IN THE NEW WORLD · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

A good set costs a dollar fifty at the beauty parlor and a dust storm can ruin it in seconds. The ladies of Elm Street have developed a system: pins, a net, a scarf and a can of hairspray strong enough to hold a crater wall.

1



Pin It Firmly

Every curl pinned flat before you step outside.

2



Add a Hair Net

Fine, invisible, essential.

3



Spray Generously

Hold the can at arm's length and do not breathe for a moment.

MATERIALS


Bobby pins


A hair net


A silk head scarf


A can of hairspray


A pocket mirror

4



Tie On a Scarf

Silk, knotted under the chin. Very Grace Kelly.

5



Walk With Your Back to the Wind

Sideways if you must. Dignity is relative.

NOTES

Sleep in a satin pillowcase and your set will last until Thursday, dust or no dust.

IMPORTANT

Do not use hairspray near Rocky. We had a small incident and Mrs. Henderson's eyebrows are growing back nicely.



6 *Unwrap and Check*

Indoors, untie, check the mirror, smile. Still perfect.

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP

Pebble showers, tremors, green sunsets and other new kinds of weather







The asteroid changed the weather. Now, as well as rain and sunshine, we have pebble showers, little tremors, green sunsets and a short, chilly spell in July that Grandfather calls 'the little winter'. None of it is dangerous if you are sensible, and some of it is downright beautiful. Here is how to keep the household humming whatever the sky decides to do.

IN THIS CHAPTER

47 Pebble Showers: Umbrellas Up!
48 Enjoying the Green Sunsets
49 Keeping the Good China on the Shelf During Tremors
50 Afternoon Tea When the Sun Won't Come Out
51 Knitting Through the Little Winter
52 Snowball Fights in July
53 Wishing on a Shooting Star (Then Ducking)

HOW TO

PEBBLE SHOWERS: UMBRELLAS UP!

SKILL 47 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 10 MINUTES · EASY

A pebble shower sounds like someone throwing gravel on the roof, because that is roughly what it is. They last a few minutes and the pebbles are no bigger than peas. The children treat them like snow days, and honestly, so does Father.

1



Listen for the Rattle

When the roof starts to rattle, everyone indoors.

2



Wait It Out

Watch from the window. It is over in a few minutes.

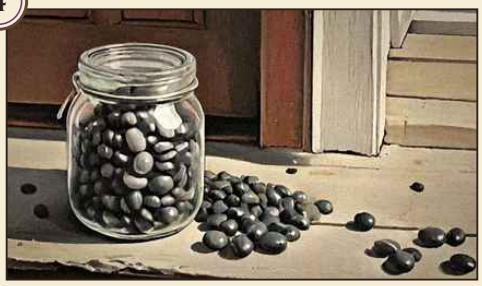
3

Umbrellas Up

Once it slows to a sprinkle, out you go under a big umbrella.



4



Collect the Best Ones

Some are shiny. Some have little sparkles. Put them in a jar.

5



Look Closely

Under the magnifying glass, they look like tiny planets.

6



Sweep the Path

Pebbles under foot are like marbles. Sweep before Grandmother comes out.

NOTES

Put a bucket upside down over the birdbath during showers. The birds appreciate it.

IMPORTANT

Do not stand under the gutter. The pebbles collect there and come down all at once.

MATERIALS

- A big black umbrella



- A metal bucket



- Rubber boots



- A collecting jar



- A magnifying glass



HOW TO

ENJOYING THE GREEN SUNSETS

SKILL 48 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 1 EVENING · EASY

Ever since the asteroid, the sunsets have been green, gold and lilac all at once, the most beautiful anyone on Elm Street has ever seen. People come from three towns over to look. The least a homemaker can do is put out some chairs.

MATERIALS


Folding lawn chairs

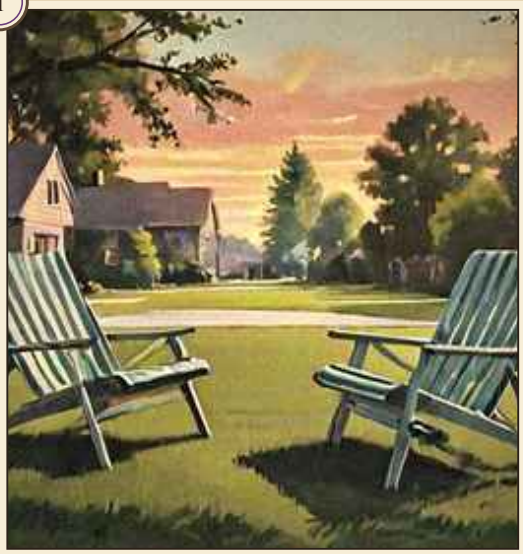

A pitcher of iced tea


A plaid blanket


A box camera


A cardigan

1



Set Out the Chairs

Facing west, a little apart, on the front lawn.

2



Pour the Iced Tea

Lemon slices, a sprig of mint, tall glasses.

3



Watch the Colors

Green first, then gold, then lilac. Do not talk during the lilac.

4



Take a Photograph

It will come out black and white, but you will remember.

5



Wrap Up Warm

It gets chilly fast. Cardigans for everyone.



6 *Wave to the Neighbors*

They are all out on their lawns too. It is like a block party with no food.

NOTES

The best sunsets come on the evening after a pebble shower. Keep the chairs handy.

IMPORTANT

Do not let the Hendersons put their chairs in front of yours. They know what they did.

HOW TO

KEEPING THE GOOD CHINA ON THE SHELF DURING TREMORS

SKILL 49 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 1 HOUR · MEDIUM

Every few days, the ground gives a little shiver and the china cabinet rattles like a nervous bride. Grandmother's wedding china has survived two moves, one flood and Father's cousin Earl. It is not going to be undone by an asteroid.

1



Take Everything Out

Carefully, one piece at a time, onto a towel on the table.

2



Line the Shelves

Rubber liner stops plates from walking.

3

Hang the Cups

Little brass hooks under each shelf. Cups hang, cups stay.



4



Stand Plates Upright

Behind a little rail, leaning back, like soldiers.

5



Latch the Doors

A good firm catch keeps the doors from swinging open.

6



Test With a Stomp

Stomp once by the cabinet. Listen. Silence is golden.

NOTES

Put the gravy boat on the bottom shelf. It is the heaviest and the most loved.

IMPORTANT

Do not let Father 'test' the cabinet by jumping. One stomp is plenty.

MATERIALS

- The good china



- A china cabinet



- Rubber shelf liner



- Small cup hooks



- A screwdriver



HOW TO

AFTERNOON TEA WHEN THE SUN WON'T COME OUT

SKILL 50 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 1 HOUR · EASY

Some days the dust is so thick that the sun never quite comes up. It is not night and it is not day, it is just dim. On those days, there is only one thing to do: light the candles, warm the pot and have a proper tea.

MATERIALS


A china teapot


Tea cups and saucers


Candles in holders


Scones


A jar of jam

1



Light the Candles

Lots of them. Dim days need bright tables.

2



Warm the Pot

Swirl hot water in the teapot first. Grandmother insists.

3



Lay the Table

Cups, saucers, a little vase. Standards are what make it tea.

4



Bring the Scones

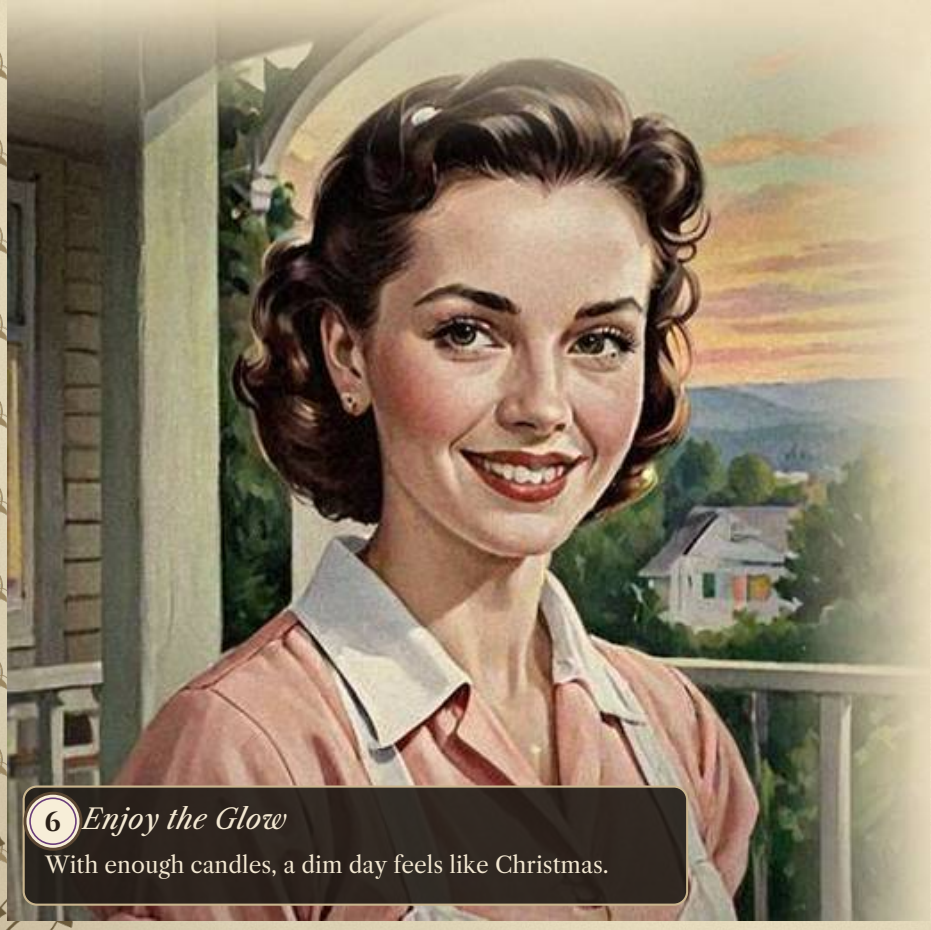
Warm from the oven, or warm from Rocky.

5



Pour Properly

Milk first or tea first. Choose a side and never apologize.



6 *Enjoy the Glow*

With enough candles, a dim day feels like Christmas.

NOTES

Invite a neighbor. Gloomy days are much less gloomy with company.

IMPORTANT

Count the candles when you light them and when you blow them out. Every time.

HOW TO

KNITTING THROUGH THE LITTLE WINTER

SKILL 51 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 2 WEEKS · MEDIUM

In July the sky clouded over and it snowed for nine days. The man on the radio called it an 'impact winter'. Grandfather calls it 'the little winter'. Grandmother calls it 'time to knit', and by the end of it every member of the family had a new sweater.

1



Measure Everyone

Chest, arms, length. Even the dog.

2



Pick the Colors

Red for Junior, yellow for Sis, brown for Father. Father always gets brown.

3

Cast On

Big needles, thick yarn. Fast work.



4



Knit by the Fire

An hour after breakfast, an hour after lunch, all evening.

5



Try It On

Halfwhy through, hold it up to the person. Adjust.

6



Hand Out the Sweaters

Everybody wears them at once for a photograph.

NOTES

Knit the dog's sweater first. It is small and it builds your confidence.

IMPORTANT

Do not knit Father a sweater with a reindeer on it. He will wear it, and he will wear it to the office.

MATERIALS

- Thick wool yarn



- Big knitting needles



- A sweater pattern



- A tape measure



- A warm fire



HOW TO

SNOWBALL FIGHTS IN JULY

SKILL 52 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

The little winter brought nine inches of snow to Elm Street in the middle of July. The children had never been so happy. A snowball fight in July is a once-in-a-lifetime event, so do it properly.

MATERIALS


Mittens


A wool hat


A warm scarf


Rubber boots


A mug of cocoa (afterward)

1



Bundle Up

Mittens, hat, scarf, boots. Shorts underneath, because it is still July.

2



Pack a Good Snowball

Firm, round, not too hard. It is a game, not a war.

3



Build a Fort

A low wall of snow. Everybody needs somewhere to duck.

4



Throw Underarm

Aim for coats, never faces. Grandmother is watching from the window.

5



Build a Snowman

Carrot nose. Father's old hat. Rocky's spare doormat for a scarf.



6 *Come In for Cocoa*

Boots off at the door. Cocoa on the table. Wet mittens on the radiator.

NOTES

Take a photograph of the snowman next to the calendar. Nobody will believe you otherwise.

IMPORTANT

Do not build the snowman near Rocky. It does not end well for the snowman.

HOW TO

WISHING ON A SHOOTING STAR (THEN DUCKING)

SKILL 53 · WHEN THE SKY ACTS UP · 1 EVENING · EASY

There are a great many more shooting stars than there used to be. Most burn up beautifully high above. A few come down as pebbles. The family has developed a routine: watch, wish, duck. In that order.

1



Lie Out on the Lawn

A big blanket, everyone in a row, looking up.

2



Find the Big Dipper

Start with what you know.

3

Watch for a Streak

Be patient. They come in bunches.



4



Make a Wish

Quickly, silently, eyes closed.

5



Then Lie Back

Hands behind your head, eyes on the sky, hat close by. It is a family rule.

6



Share the Cocoa

Pass the thermos down the row. Talk about your wishes. Or don't.

NOTES

August is the best month for shooting stars, asteroid or no asteroid.

IMPORTANT

Do not wish for another asteroid. Junior did once, as a joke, and Mother did not speak to him until supper.

MATERIALS

- A plaid blanket



- A thermos of cocoa



- A star chart



- A flashlight with red cellophane



- A sturdy hat



CHAPTER NINE

9

BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD

Parties, prizes and the cheerful homemaker every crater needs







The dust is settling. The sky is turning blue again in the mornings. The ducks are fat, the tomatoes are enormous and Rocky hums happily on the back step. Our street is closer than it ever was before the asteroid. This last chapter is about celebrating, because a homemaker who has kept her family fed, clean and cheerful through the end of the world has earned a party.

IN THIS CHAPTER

54 Throwing a Crater-Rim Block Party
55 Winning the Garden Club Prize With a Giant Tomato
56 Running a Meteorite Lemonade Stand
57 A Birthday Cake for the Asteroid
58 Welcoming the Relief Truck With a Hot Pie
59 The Christmas Card Photo in Front of the Crater
60 Being the Homemaker Every Crater Needs

HOW TO

THROWING A CRATER-RIM BLOCK PARTY

SKILL 54 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

When the whole street has a crater, the whole street should have a party. Ours was held around the Hendersons' crater, which is the biggest, with bunting, a potluck and Father's famous punch.

1



Hang the Bunting

From porch to porch, right across the street.

2



Set Up the Tables

Long tables down the middle of the road, cloths on top.

3



Lay Out the Potluck

Casseroles at one end, desserts at the other, Jell-O in the middle.

MATERIALS



Red, white and blue bunting



Long folding tables



Paper lanterns



A punch bowl



A portable record player

4



Mix the Punch

Fruit juice, ginger ale and a scoop of sherbet. Father's secret.

5



Light the Lanterns

As the sun goes down. They make even a crater look romantic.

NOTES

Give every family a job. Many hands make light work and a very good party.

IMPORTANT

Fence off the crater before the dancing starts. The Hendersons learned this at their own party.



6 *Dance in the Street*

Put on a record. Everybody dances. Even Mr. Fenwick.

HOW TO

WINNING THE GARDEN CLUB PRIZE WITH A GIANT TOMATO

SKILL 55 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · 1 SUMMER · MEDIUM

For thirty-one years, Mrs. Henderson's roses have won the Elm Street Garden Club prize. This year Grandfather entered one of his crater tomatoes. It weighed sixty-four pounds. It took the blue ribbon, and Mrs. Henderson has not quite recovered.

MATERIALS

- A giant tomato



- A wheelbarrow



- A soft cloth



- A bathroom scale



- Your best cardigan



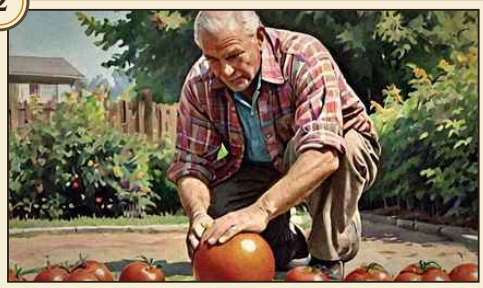
1



Choose the Best One

Round, red, no cracks. Grandfather knew it the moment he saw it.

2



Polish It

A soft cloth and a little elbow grease. Shine sells.

3

Weigh It

On the bathroom scale. Then sit down for a moment.



4



Wheel It to the Show

Slowly. Over the curb with help. It does not bounce.

5



Wait for the Judges

Stand beside it modestly. Do not mention the crater.

6



Accept the Ribbon

Hold it up for the judges, smile, and say something kind about the roses.

NOTES

Give Mrs. Henderson a few seeds. Next year, we can all be friends again.

IMPORTANT

Do not let the tomato fall off the table. It weighed sixty-four pounds. The judge's foot is fine.

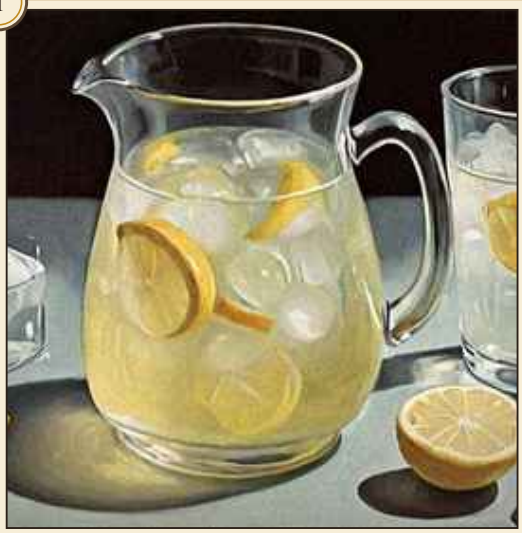
HOW TO

RUNNING A METEORITE LEMONADE STAND

SKILL 56 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

Since the asteroid, folks have driven in from all over to see the crater. Our daughter saw an opportunity. Lemonade for a nickel, a look at Rocky for a penny, and a guided tour of the crater rim for a dime. She has made eleven dollars.

1



Make the Lemonade

Lemons, sugar, cold water, lots of ice. Taste it twice.

2



Set Up the Stand

A card table at the end of the drive, a cloth on top.

3



Paint a Sign

Big letters, bright colors. Spell 'lemonade' right.

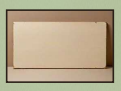
MATERIALS


A small card table


A pitcher of lemonade


Paper cups


A cigar box for money


A painted sign

4



Pour With a Smile

Half full is cheating. Fill it to the line.

5



Show Off Rocky

Visitors may look but not touch. Rocky is shy.

NOTES

Sell cookies too. Thirsty people are hungry people.

IMPORTANT

Do not sell pieces of Rocky, no matter how much the gentleman from Chicago offers.



6 *Count the Nickels*

Put half in the piggy bank. Spend the other half on candy.

HOW TO

A BIRTHDAY CAKE FOR THE ASTEROID

SKILL 57 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

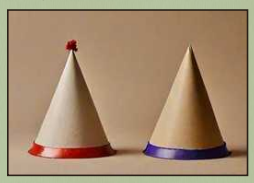
- A three-layer cake



- One big birthday candle



- Party hats



- Streamers



- A camera



One year after the asteroid landed in the rose bed, the family held a party for it. It sounds silly. It is not. A year ago we were frightened; now we have a pond, ducks, prize tomatoes and the nicest street in America. That deserves a cake.

1



Bake Three Layers

Chocolate, of course. Asteroids are dark.

2



Frost It Generously

Chocolate all over, candies on top. Asteroids are not subtle.

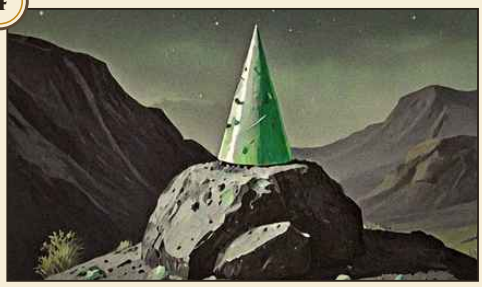
3

Hang the Streamers

From the porch light to the crater fence.



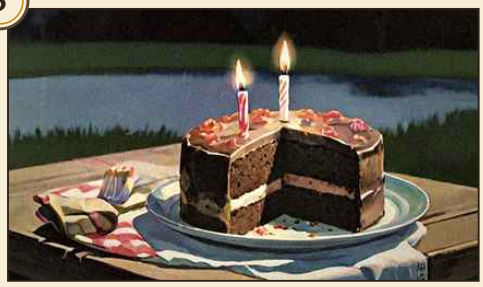
4



Put on the Hats

Everyone wears a hat. Even Rocky gets a little one.

5



Light the Candles

One for the year, one to grow on. Make a wish. Not for another asteroid.

6



Sing

'Happy Impact Day to you.' Grandfather sings the bass part.

NOTES

Save a slice for the scientists. They will be by on the anniversary, they always are.

IMPORTANT

Do not put the cake on Rocky. Rocky is warm. The cake will remember this.

HOW TO

WELCOMING THE RELIEF TRUCK WITH A HOT PIE

SKILL 58 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · 1 MORNING · EASY

When the first relief truck finally rumbled down Elm Street with flour, sugar and fresh oranges, the whole street turned out. Most people brought shopping bags. Our homemaker brought a pie, because the driver had come a very long way.

1



Bake Something Hot

Cherry, from the last precious jar. Some occasions deserve it.

2



Listen for the Horn

Two long honks means the truck has turned onto Elm.

3



Wait at the Curb

Pie in your hands, smile on your face.

MATERIALS



A hot cherry pie



Pot holders



A thermos of coffee



A shopping bag



A thank-you card

4



Thank the Driver

Pie first, coffee second, questions third.

5



Collect Your Share

Take what you need and not a scrap more. There are other streets.

NOTES

Oranges were the thing everyone missed most. Give one to every child on the street.

IMPORTANT

Never block the truck to get first pick. Mrs. Henderson tried it. The truck won.



6 *Write a Card*

Send a thank-you card to the relief office. Someone should.

HOW TO

THE CHRISTMAS CARD PHOTO IN FRONT OF THE CRATER

SKILL 59 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- A camera on a tripod



- The family's sweaters



- A big red bow



- A box of Christmas cards



- A pen and stamps



Every year the family sends a Christmas card with a photograph. This year there was only one possible backdrop. Father set up the camera on a tripod, everybody wore their little-winter sweaters and the ducks very kindly stayed in shot.

1



Set Up the Tripod

Level, steady, pointed at the pond. Ducks in frame.

2



Tie a Bow on the Fence

A big red bow on the crater gate. Very festive.

3

Line Up the Family

Tall at the back, short at the front, dog in the middle.



4



Set the Timer

Press the button and run. Ten seconds. Smile on the way.

5



Develop the Film

The drugstore does it in a week. Order sixty.

6



Mail the Cards

One to everyone, even Aunt Edna, who will frame it.

NOTES

Take three. The first one, somebody blinks. The second one, the dog leaves. The third one is the card.

IMPORTANT

Stand well back from the crater edge. Everybody steps back when they smile.

HOW TO

BEING THE HOMEMAKER EVERY CRATER NEEDS

SKILL 60 · BRIGHTER DAYS AHEAD · A LIFETIME · HARD

In the end, it was not the shelter, the pantry or the fence that got our family through the asteroid. It was Mother, with her apron on, keeping breakfast hot, the step swept and everyone's chin up. This last skill is the most important in the book.

1



Get Up First

Before the dust, before the radio, before Father.

2



Put the Coffee On

The smell of coffee tells a family the world is still turning.

3



Smile Anyway

Even on dim days. Especially on dim days.

MATERIALS


A clean apron


A full pantry


A tidy kitchen


A pot of coffee


A cheerful heart

4



Keep the Table Set

Cloth, napkins, a flower in a glass. Every day.

5



Look After the Street

Casseroles, coffee for the warden, a word for the Hendersons.

NOTES

The world will always end a little bit, one way or another. Somebody still has to make breakfast.

IMPORTANT

Do not do all of it yourself. Hand Father a dish towel. He can learn.



6 *Rest When It's Done*

Sit on the porch at sunset. Look at the crater. Laugh a little.

APPENDIX

Charts, checklists and quick references

A. FIELD GUIDE TO THE CRATER AGE

Who and what you are likely to meet, where to find them and how to handle them. When in doubt, offer coffee.

WHO OR WHAT	WHERE FOUND	LOOKS LIKE	FOND OF	HANDLE WITH
Rocky (meteorite)	The back step	Green glow, pumpkin size	Marshmallows, warmth	Oven mitts
The crater	Where the roses were	Forty feet across	Rain, ducks	A nice fence
Mr. Fenwick (warden)	Elm Street, twice a day	White helmet, armband	Three sugars	Doughnuts
The scientists	A tent by the crater	Lab coats, clipboards	Long words, pie	Patience
Mr. Kowalski (grocer)	Main Street	Apron, pencil, frown	Canned peaches	Firm haggling
Buster (beagle)	Near Rocky, digging	Floppy ears	Biscuits, burying	A firm 'No'
Petey (canary)	The parlor	Small, yellow, flappy	Apple slices	A cage cover
Mrs. Henderson	Next door, over the fence	Pearls, opinions	Her roses	Seeds and kindness
Aunt Edna	Ohio, by letter	Worried handwriting	News, drawings	Cheerful letters

B. THE PANTRY CHART

How long things keep, what they are best for and what they will fetch at Mr. Kowalski's grocery. Rates change daily; check the chalkboard.

PANTRY ITEM	KEEPS	BEST USE	TRADE VALUE AT THE GROCER
Canned soup	2 years	Casseroles, cold nights	1 can = 1 loaf of bread
Canned ham	2 years	Sunday roast, fritters	1 can = 1 chicken
Luncheon meat	Forever, apparently	Fritters for company	1 can = a pound of butter
Powdered milk	1 year	Cocoa, sauces, pudding	1 box = 6 eggs
Soda crackers	6 months	Mock apple pie	1 box = 1 lemon
Gelatin	Forever	Salads that survive tremors	3 boxes = 1 orange
Maraschino cherries	Until opened	Emergencies, morale	Name your price
Mystery cans	Unknown	Mystery Night	Do not trade; open

C. CHECKLISTS

Copy these pages and tick items off as you get ready. Check the pantry and the candles every week.

THE FALLOUT PANTRY SHELF

- ☐ Canned soup (two dozen)
- ☐ Canned ham and luncheon meat
- ☐ Powdered milk
- ☐ Soda crackers (for mock apple pie)
- ☐ Gelatin in three flavors
- ☐ Dried beans, rice and macaroni
- ☐ Flour and sugar, off the floor
- ☐ A jar of maraschino cherries
- ☐ A hand-crank can opener
- ☐ Water in every jar
- ☐ Candles and matches
- ☐ A grease pencil for dating cans

THE SHELTER SHELF

- ☐ Board games and a jigsaw
- ☐ Two oil lamps
- ☐ Quilts for every bunk
- ☐ A storybook
- ☐ A nightlight
- ☐ Yarn and needles for Grandmother
- ☐ Dog biscuits for Buster
- ☐ A first-aid kit
- ☐ A tube radio and spare batteries

FOR A HAPPY CRATER-RIM PARTY

- ☐ Fence checked and gate latched
- ☐ Bunting from porch to porch
- ☐ Long tables in the street
- ☐ Casseroles at one end, pies at the other
- ☐ Father's punch with sherbet
- ☐ Paper lanterns
- ☐ A record player
- ☐ A plate for Mr. Fenwick
- ☐ A slice for the scientists
- ☐ Rocky in his party hat

D. HOUSEHOLD REMEDIES FOR CRATER-AGE MISHAPS

Every asteroid causes a little bother sooner or later. Here is what to do, calmly, with your apron on.

MISHAP	REMEDY	NOTES
Dust on everything	Damp cloth, top to bottom	Sing while you do it
Labels fell off the cans	Shake, weigh, guess	Then enjoy Mystery Night
Cake sank in a tremor	Fill with chocolate	Call it Crater Cake
Gelatin collapsed	Spoon into glasses	Call it a parfait
Gray streaks on the wash	Rewash, dry in the basement	Check the wind next time
Pebbles in the gutter	Ladder, scoop, bucket	Father, with Mother holding the ladder
Dog trying to bury Rocky	Biscuit and a firm 'No'	Every morning
Tomato rolled into crater	Ladder and a blanket	Pick them before they are ripe
Hairdo ruined by dust	Pins, net, spray, scarf	In that order
Canary flapping	Cover the cage	Same for Father
Cookies vanishing	Night watchman with a bell	Usually Grandfather
Power out at breakfast	Camp stove on the back step	Never indoors

E. HANDY CRATER-AGE CONVERSIONS

MEASURE	ROUGHLY EQUALS
1 crater (backyard size)	1 very nice duck pond
1 giant tomato	40 sandwiches
1 sad iron, hot	1 shirt, if you do not chat
1 pebble shower	3 minutes under an umbrella
1 Rocky (meteorite)	1 oven set to 350
1 can of peaches	1 pound of butter
1 dim day	12 candles
1 tremor	1 wobbling gelatin salad
1 little winter	1 sweater per person (and the dog)
1 cup of coffee, 3 sugars	1 happy warden
1 cheerful homemaker	1 whole street, cheered

F. HOUSEHOLD CRATER CARD

Fill this in together and pin a copy by the telephone and inside the shelter door.

Household name	
Date of impact	
Crater size (paces across)	
Can opener is kept in	
Candles and matches are kept in	
Water jars (count)	
Shelter key is kept in	
Rocky's spot	
Today's rate for peaches	
Warden's name and rounds	
Next block party	
Never trade	

IMPORTANT NUMBERS

Emergency	911
The doctor	
Father's office	
Grandmother	
The Garden Club	
First Methodist (the Reverend)	
Civil Defense warden	
The university (for the scientists)	

G. GLOSSARY

Aftershock. A little shiver of the ground some days after the big thump. Hard on gelatin.

Asteroid. A rock from space. Ours landed in the rose bed on a Tuesday.

Chondrite. A word the scientists use. Nod and offer pie.

Civil Defense. The kind men in white helmets who make the lists.

Crater. A hole with ambition. Fence it, fill it, add ducks.

Crater Cake. A cake that sank on purpose. The most requested dessert on Elm Street.

Dim day. A day when the sun never quite gets up. Light candles and have tea.

Duck and cover. A drill. Also, a good description of the ducks in our pond.

Fallout pantry. An ordinary pantry with ambition.

Impact Day. The anniversary of the asteroid. Celebrated with cake.

Little winter. Nine days of snow in July. Time to knit.

Meteorite. The piece of the asteroid that you can actually hold. See Rocky.

Mock apple pie. Grandmother's crackers-and-lemon miracle. Contains no apples.

Mystery Night. Supper made from one can with no label. Exciting.

Pebble shower. Little space pebbles falling like hail. Umbrellas up.

Rocky. Our meteorite. Warm, green, humming, much loved. Do not lick.

Sad iron. A heavy iron you heat on a stove. Nothing sad about it.

Warden. Mr. Fenwick. Three sugars.

H. WHERE TO LEARN MORE

- **Housekeeping:** your public library has excellent books on the home. They do not mention asteroids, but the principles hold.
- **Gardening:** the county extension office, the Garden Club and Grandfather, who grew a sixty-four-pound tomato.
- **Cookery:** Mother's recipe box, the church cookbook and Grandmother, who cooked through the Depression and is ready to do it again.
- **Real emergencies:** your local Civil Defense office and the radio. Listen to them first, and to this book second.
- **Good neighbors:** the folks next door. Take them a casserole.

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MY SKILLS LOG

Tick off each skill once your household has done it. Do not let Father tick them for you. He ticks the ones he watched.

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
01	Discovering a Crater Where the Rose Bed Was		☐
02	Sweeping Space Dust off the Front Step		☐
03	Tuning In to the Emergency Broadcast		☐
04	Checking on the Neighbors (With a Casserole)		☐
05	Calming the Canary (and Father)		☐
06	Serving Breakfast When the Power Is Out		☐
07	Stocking the Fallout Pantry		☐
08	Labeling Cans After the Labels Fall Off		☐
09	Making Powdered Milk Taste Like Milk		☐
10	Opening a Can Without the Electric Opener		☐
11	Rationing the Cookies So Father Doesn't Notice		☐
12	Storing Water in Every Jar in the House		☐
13	Keeping the Pantry Safe From Midnight Snackers		☐
14	The Mystery-Can Casserole		☐
15	Biscuits Baked on a Warm Meteorite		☐
16	Mock Apple Pie (No Apples Since Tuesday)		☐
17	Sunday Roast on the Camp Stove		☐
18	Luncheon Meat Fritters for Company		☐
19	Crater Cake (It's Supposed to Sink)		☐
20	A Gelatin Salad That Survives the Tremors		☐
21	Dusting When Everything Is Dust		☐
22	Hanging Out the Wash Under an Orange Sky		☐
23	Sealing the Windows With Tape and a Smile		☐
24	Vacuuming the Ash Out of the Rug		☐
25	Choosing Curtains to Hide the Crater View		☐
26	A Mat for Every Door (and Shoes Off, Father)		☐
27	Ironing Without Electricity		☐
28	Putting a Nice Fence Around the Crater		☐
29	Growing Tomatoes in Crater Soil		☐
30	Living With a Glowing Space Rock		☐
31	A Picnic on the Crater Rim		☐
32	Hosting the Scientists Who Came to Look		☐
33	Turning the Crater Into a Duck Pond		☐
34	Making the Shelter Feel Like Home		☐
35	Board Games by Lantern Light		☐
36	Bedtime in the Bunk Beds		☐
37	Duck and Cover Drills Everyone Enjoys		☐
38	Keeping Grandmother Busy in Close Quarters		☐

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
39	Explaining the Situation to the Dog		☐
40	Shopping When the Grocer Takes Canned Goods		☐
41	Wearing a Hat Against Falling Pebbles		☐
42	The Church Bake Sale Goes On		☐
43	Driving Around the Craters		☐
44	Writing to Aunt Edna About the Asteroid		☐
45	Making Friends With the Civil Defense Warden		☐
46	Keeping Your Hairdo in a Dust Storm		☐
47	Pebble Showers: Umbrellas Up!		☐
48	Enjoying the Green Sunsets		☐
49	Keeping the Good China on the Shelf During Tremors		☐
50	Afternoon Tea When the Sun Won't Come Out		☐
51	Knitting Through the Little Winter		☐
52	Snowball Fights in July		☐
53	Wishing on a Shooting Star (Then Ducking)		☐
54	Throwing a Crater-Rim Block Party		☐
55	Winning the Garden Club Prize With a Giant Tomato		☐
56	Running a Meteorite Lemonade Stand		☐
57	A Birthday Cake for the Asteroid		☐
58	Welcoming the Relief Truck With a Hot Pie		☐
59	The Christmas Card Photo in Front of the Crater		☐
60	Being the Homemaker Every Crater Needs		☐

NOTES

Recipes tried, cans traded, craters fenced and every pebble shower survived.

THE BOOK EVERY SENSIBLE FAMILY NEEDS

It landed on a Tuesday, which is wash day. Where the prize roses used to be there is now a crater forty feet across, the sky has turned the color of orange sherbet, a glowing green meteorite is keeping the back step warm and the grocer will only take canned peaches. Father says it will blow over. Somebody had better get breakfast on the table.

Homemaking After the Asteroid is here to help: sixty cheerful skills, each laid out on a single page with a picture for every step, a materials panel and notes on what can go wrong. Recipes for the fallout pantry, housekeeping in the dust and parties on the crater rim. Tabs on every page help you find what you need, even during a pebble shower.

INSIDE YOU WILL LEARN HOW TO

- Fence a crater and fill it with ducks
- Bake biscuits on a warm meteorite
- Make mock apple pie with no apples
- Label cans after the labels fall off
- Haggle with tins at the grocery
- Keep your hairdo in a dust storm
- Save the good china from tremors
- Win the Garden Club with a giant tomato
- Make the shelter feel like home
- Keep everyone's chin up



"A crater is just a hole with ambition."

MOTHER, THE MORNING AFTER

HOMEMAKING AFTER THE ASTEROID

Household / Cookery / Humor

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION